

Two advanced units launched in Pithampur with Rs 850 crore investment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Pithampur

Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Dr Mohan Yadav on Thursday inaugurated two modern manufacturing units set up by the Pratap Group at the Smart Industrial Park in Pithampur with a combined investment of Rs 850 crore. The two units — Corsis Industries and Walters Technologies — are focused on advanced manufacturing, optical fibre and energy storage technologies. The projects are expected to create new employment opportunities for hundreds of young people and strengthen Madhya Pradesh's industrial capabilities.

Addressing the inauguration programme, Yadav said India had entered a new phase of development and self-reliance under Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Madhya Pradesh was advancing alongside the country's growth journey. He said the new industrial units would contribute to development and prosperity while creating employment opportunities. Yadav said providing jobs to young people and strengthening the economy were among the government's key priorities. He said industries based on modern technologies such as optical fibre and lithium batteries were important in view of future requirements.

The units being established with German technology support would provide international-level manufactur-



ing capabilities as well as opportunities for young people to receive training in advanced technologies.

The Chief Minister said the state government was providing support to industries through incentives and infrastructure. Industries generating employment can receive assistance of up to Rs 5,000 per worker, while the government is also focusing on providing electricity, water, roads and other essential infrastructure.

Union Tourism and Culture Minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat said the two units represented the changing industrial landscape of India and the country's drive towards self-reliance. He said the battery storage plant would support growing clean-energy requirements,

while the optical fibre facility would strengthen digital connectivity and communications infrastructure.

According to the group, the optical fibre plant has been established over about 8,067 square metres and has an annual production capacity of 5.5 million fibre kilometres. It is expected to generate around 300 direct and indirect employment opportunities. Its products will cater to broadband connectivity, 5G networks, FTTH, data centres, smart cities, defence and strategic communication infrastructure.

The Walters Technologies plant, spread over about 20,505 square metres, has a production capacity of 3 GWh and is expected to generate around 250 direct and indirect jobs. The facility incorpo-

rates Industry 4.0-based automation and robotic assembly lines and will cater to renewable energy integration and commercial and industrial applications.

Shekhawat said the group currently provides direct and indirect employment to around 30,000 people, while more than 2,000 youth are being trained at its skill development centres.

The group is also working towards creating employment opportunities for around 5,000 more people in the coming years.

The projects are also expected to strengthen the state's industrial ecosystem by expanding local capabilities in high-value manufacturing and creating opportunities for technology-driven businesses.

GOI report: MP ranks 2nd nationally in citizen satisfaction

SARMAN NAGELE n Bhopal

The Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances (DARPG), Government of India, has released the 47th monthly report of CPGRAMS (Centralised Public Grievance Redress and Monitoring System), highlighting the performance of states and Union Territories for June 2026. According to the report, a total of 96,190 grievances were received in June 2026, out of which 93,170 were disposed of. As of June 30, 2026, 2,16,032 cases remained pending, representing a 26% increase compared to December 2025.

According to official information received by MPPOST, a total of 75,318 feedbacks were received via the Feedback Call Center in June 2026, with 33,092 coming from states and Union Territories. Overall, 14,979 grievances were considered resolved, reflecting a resolution rate of 45%. Of these, 70% of citizens expressed satisfaction. Madhya Pradesh



emerged as a leading state in the country, securing second place with a 78% citizen satisfaction rate.

The CPGRAMS report highlighted a dual performance by MP - ranking 7th in grievance resolution and 2nd in citizen satisfaction nationwide, showcasing strong administrative work culture and efficiency. Reacting to this achievement, Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Dr. Mohan Yadav credited the state's work culture and administrative efficiency. He stated that the state is moving forward under the guidance of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. The Chief Minister congratulat-



ed the state's administrative machinery on this achievement and urged them to strive toward making Madhya Pradesh the top state in the nation in the coming days.

The Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances (DARPG) serves as the nodal agency of the Government of India for administrative reforms, resolving public grievances concerning state and central government agencies, and promoting successful good governance practices. Key Findings of the Report, Top Performers in Resolution. Uttar Pradesh ranked first in

resolving grievances during June, disposing of 31,460 cases. The remaining top five states included Maharashtra (7,619), Haryana (7,183), Gujarat (6,390), and Delhi (6,076). Madhya Pradesh Monthly Performance: MP ranked 7th in grievance disposal for June 2026, receiving 5,083 new complaints and disposing of 4,703 cases, leaving 11,851 pending cases at the end of the month. Six-Month Overview (Jan-Jun 2026) During this period, Madhya Pradesh received 24,717 new grievances. Including previously pending cases, the total stood at 35,099. MP resolved 23,248 complaints during these six months, with 11,851 cases remaining pending as of June 30, 2026. Pending Cases, MP ranked fifth in total pending cases over the six-month period. Regarding grievances pending for over 21 days between January 1 and June 30, 2026, Maharashtra topped the list with 25,453 cases, while Madhya Pradesh ranked 7th with 8,807 pending cases in this category.

Diggy seeks correction of land records for loan-cleared farmers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Bhopal

Veteran Congress leader and former Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Digvijay Singh has urged Chief Minister Mohan Yadav to ensure the removal of mortgage entries from land records of farmers who have repaid loans taken from the now-defunct Bhumi Vikas Bank.

In a letter to Yadav, Singh said mortgage entries continued to appear in the revenue records of several farmers despite repayment of their loans or settlement of outstanding dues. He said the entries were creating difficulties in selling land, completing mutation, partitioning property and undertaking other land-related transactions.

The Madhya Pradesh Rajiya Sahakari Krishi Evam Gramin Vikas Bank, popularly known as Bhumi Vikas Bank, had provided long-term agricultural loans against mortgaged land. The bank has since been closed and is under liquidation. Singh said the issue was brought to his notice by Kedar Sirohi, a former member of the Madhya Pradesh Krishi Salahkar Parishad from Harda.

Two held for abduction, rape

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE n Bhopal

Two men have been arrested after a Class 9 student, who went missing from her home in Bhopal's Govindpura area on July 21, alleged that she was abducted and sexually assaulted.

According to police, the girl was allegedly taken to Mandideep by a neighbour, identified as Vikas, who kept her confined in a room for nearly a month and allegedly raped her multiple times.

Police traced her location and recovered her from Mandideep on Wednesday night. Based on her statement, a case of rape was registered on Thursday morning.

During questioning, the girl also alleged that another neighbour, Deepak Sahu, who is married, had sexually assaulted her. Police subsequently registered a separate case against him and arrested him.

Police said Vikas was arrested after the girl was traced to Mandideep. Both accused are now in custody and further investigation is underway. The police are examining the circumstances surrounding the girl's disappearance and the allegations made in her statement.

CM sets 10,000 annual training target for skills park

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Bhopal

The Sant Shiromani Ravidas Global Skills Park in Bhopal will eventually train 10,000 youths every year to meet the evolving requirements of industry, Chief Minister Dr Mohan Yadav said on Thursday.

Addressing an orientation programme at the park, Yadav said the institution currently certifies around 2,000 trainees annually through various skill courses, while the number is expected to rise to 3,000 in 2026. He said the capacity would be expanded progressively to meet industry demand.

Yadav said Prime Minister Narendra Modi had consistently prioritised skill development and was expanding opportunities for young people. He said Madhya Pradesh, traditionally an agriculture-based state, must

also build its strength in skills and technology to enable youth to secure better livelihoods. Students from Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Rajasthan and other states are currently receiving training at the park.

Referring to Sant Ravidas, whose 650th birth anniversary year is being observed, Yadav said his life demonstrated the importance of dedication to work, self-reliance and confidence in one's skills. He emphasised that no occupation should be considered small or big and encouraged trainees to develop their abilities and pursue excellence.

The Chief Minister highlighted the park's 98.9 per cent placement rate and said its world-class, multilingual programmes were helping young people adapt to rapidly changing technologies. He interacted with

trainees in advanced laboratories, including engine, autotronics and CNC and precision engineering facilities, and heard about their training and employment prospects.

A total of 550 newly enrolled trainees participated in the orientation programme. Yadav also inaugurated a newly constructed multipurpose sports complex, visited training laboratories and interacted with students about their courses and career plans.

Industry representatives said the park's infrastructure, modern laboratories and industry-oriented training were producing job-ready candidates. Several companies said they were recruiting trainees from the institution and would continue to require skilled manpower. Representatives also called for expanding training capacity, particularly for

women.

Yadav said the government was also strengthening ITIs located near industrial areas and aligning training with local industry requirements to create a larger pool of skilled workers.

Skill Development and Employment Minister Gautam Tetwal said the park trained about 2,000 students in 2025 and was expected to reach around 3,000 in 2026. The long-term target is to train 6,000 students annually and eventually expand full capacity to 10,000. He said sectors such as automobiles, electronics, robotics, artificial intelligence and advanced manufacturing were creating new employment opportunities.

Three MoUs were also signed. Bajaj Auto Foundation will establish an industry-based training centre for two- and three-wheeler service technicians.



Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav witnesses a MoU with a reputed company at the orientation ceremony of trainees at Sant Shiromani Ravidas Global Skills Park in Bhopal on Thursday. Yadav. Pioneer photo

Mahakaushali cow gets national breed recognition

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Jabalpur

The Mahakaushali cow has been officially recognised as an independent indigenous cattle breed by the ICAR-National Bureau of Animal Genetic Resources (NBAGR), Karnal, marking a significant achievement in the conservation and characterisation of India's native livestock breeds.

The recognition was granted at the 14th meeting of the NBAGR Breed Registration Committee. With this, Mahakaushali has become the 57th registered indigenous cattle breed of India. NBAGR has allotted the breed the accession number INDIA_CATTLE_1000_MAHAKAUSHALI_03057.

The achievement has been led by Dr Mohan Singh Thakur, Professor and Head of the Department of Animal Genetics and Breeding at the College of Veterinary Science and Animal Husbandry, Nanaji Deshmukh Veterinary Science University (NDVSU), Jabalpur.

The research was conducted between 2018 and 2022 under an NBAGR-supported project. The study focused on documenting the breed's dis-

tinctive characteristics and establishing its genetic identity. Following submission of the formal registration application and breed descriptor, the national committee undertook detailed verification of the scientific data and genetic characteristics before granting official recognition.

The university said the recognition represents an important milestone in the conservation of Madhya Pradesh's indigenous animal genetic resources. It is also expected to contribute to the socio-economic development of local livestock keepers by strengthening recognition and conservation of the native breed. NDVSU Vice-Chancellor Dr Mandeeep Sharma congratulated the scientific team on the achievement.

He said the recognition would serve as an important milestone in conserving Madhya Pradesh's biodiversity and supporting the socio-economic advancement of local livestock farmers.

The university said the recognition reflects the outcome of sustained scientific research and efforts to document and preserve indigenous livestock resources.

BOI opens second Rewa branch

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Jabalpur

Bank of India (BOI) has opened its 54th branch under the Jabalpur zone in Rewa, expanding its banking network in the city.

The new branch was inaugurated by Sanjay Srivastava, Field General Manager, Bhopal, under the guidance of Ramesh Kumar, Zonal Manager, Bank of India, Jabalpur zone. It is the bank's second branch in Rewa city. The new branch is expected to benefit residents, farmers, traders and students in the surrounding areas by providing access to banking services closer to their homes and businesses.

Ramesh Kumar welcomed the guests at the inauguration and highlighted the benefits the new branch would offer to people in Rewa and nearby areas.

The programme was attended by branch heads Aditi Gupta, Abhishek Sharma and Santosh Dwivedi, along with other bank officials and employees. The expansion is expected to strengthen the bank's presence in Rewa and improve access to banking services for the local community.

Two teachers removed after students raise complaints

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Chhindwara

Two teachers at a government school in Bichbehri village of Chhindwara district's Junnardeo assembly constituency have been removed following complaints by students and parents about their conduct and alleged failure to conduct regular classes.

A video recorded by students on August 15 surfaced in which schoolgirls were seen raising concerns about the teacher in-charge and a guest female teacher. The students alleged that although both teachers attended school, classes were not conducted regularly and the teachers often remained occupied with their mobile phones.

The students also alleged that the school, which is scheduled to close at 4.30 pm, often sent them home around 3 pm. They further made serious allegations regarding the teachers' conduct, prompting the administration to order an inquiry.

The issue was first raised at a gram sabha meeting on

August 16 and was subsequently taken to the district administration's public hearing. Parents alleged that they had earlier approached education and tribal welfare officials but no action was taken. They demanded that both teachers be removed and replaced so that regular teaching could resume.

Assistant Commissioner of the Tribal Development Department Satyendra Singh Markam said both teachers had been removed from the school and directions had been issued to register an FIR against them. He said an investigation would be conducted and strict action would follow if the allegations were established. The accused teacher, however, denied the allegations and claimed he was being unnecessarily targeted. He alleged that the students had been influenced because another candidate for the guest teacher position, who is on the waiting list, wanted the post.

The administration has initiated an investigation into the allegations.

Excise team seizes illegal liquor

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Mhow

The Excise Department seized 34 boxes of illegally stored liquor during a raid at a house in Banjari, under the Mhow-B circle, on Thursday.

Acting on a tip-off, an excise team searched the premises at Sunrise Town and recovered four boxes of London Pride whisky, six boxes of Limout beer, 16 boxes of plain country liquor and eight boxes of spiced country liquor.

The seized stock totalled 324 bulk litres and was valued at approximately Rs 1.54 lakh.

A case has been registered under Sections 34(1) and 34(2) of the Madhya Pradesh Excise Act, 1915. The department is investigating the source of the liquor and the possible involvement of other persons in its illegal supply.

The Excise Department said its campaign against the illegal sale and transportation of liquor would continue across the district.

The department is also tracing the supply chain to identify the source of the seized liquor and prevent further illegal distribution.

Bhopal plans rehab-focused campaign against beggary

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Bhopal

The Bhopal district administration has begun efforts to make the city free of begging, with Collector Priyank Mishra directing officials to adopt a rehabilitation-focused approach similar to the model implemented in Indore.

A review meeting on the Nasha Mukht Bharat and Beggary-Free Bhopal campaigns was held on Thursday. Mishra directed the Social Justice Department, Bhopal Municipal Corporation and Pravesh organisation to work in coordination and conduct a comprehensive campaign to identify and rescue people engaged in begging.

He stressed that rescue operations must be accompanied by effective rehabilitation and counselling arrangements.

The administration will also undertake awareness activities to discourage people from giving alms and encourage community participation in the campaign. A detailed action plan will be prepared based on Indore's rehabilitation-focused

model.

The Collector also reviewed implementation of the district Drug Demand Reduction Plan under the Nasha Mukht Bharat campaign. Officials were directed to identify areas vulnerable to drug abuse and conduct regular awareness programmes in schools and colleges. The Social Justice Department was asked to prepare a detailed micro-level action plan for the campaign.

Mishra appealed to citizens to share information about drug trafficking or the illegal sale of narcotic substances without fear. He said the identity of informants would be kept confidential.

Citizens can provide information through the toll-free number 1933 or the NCB MANAS portal. Joint teams of the police and administration are also conducting surprise inspections in vulnerable areas and taking action against the illegal drug trade.

The administration will also focus on strengthening coordination among departments and field teams so that identified cases are followed up systematically.

City to be made free of black spots, unsafe left turns

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Bhopal

Bhopal will be developed as a city free of road black spots and unsafe left turns, Commissioner Karmveer Sharma said while reviewing road safety, infrastructure and development projects with officials on Thursday.

Sharma directed the traffic police, municipal corporation and construction agencies to work in coordination to identify and remove black spots across Bhopal and adjoining areas. Where immediate removal is not possible, effective road signs and safety indicators should be installed to alert motorists.

Expressing concern over the slow progress of the overbridge under construction in Sant Hirdaram Nagar, the Commissioner directed

officials to complete the work within the stipulated timeline. He specifically instructed that bridge-related work in the Bairagarh market area be completed within the next two months to facilitate smoother traffic movement.

Sharma also reviewed roads leading to tourist destinations such as Sanchi and Bhojpur in view of the proposed Global Investors Summit in Bhopal next January. He directed agencies to ensure that roads connecting the city with these important destinations remain in good condition.

He also called for prompt repairs of roads damaged during the monsoon and directed officials to prevent waterlogging. Roads affected by Metro construction should be restored without delay, with Metro authorities and

other construction agencies coordinating to ensure smooth traffic movement.

The Commissioner directed agencies responsible for road maintenance to respond quickly to complaints and ensure that repair work begins without delay. He also reviewed the progress of National Highway projects and directed officials to construct an approach road near the flyover at the Bhopal bypass-Raisen junction. Adequate signage and reflective markings should also be installed to improve road safety.

In another meeting, Sharma reviewed the proposed Grid Control of India control centre complex in the Aero City Bhopal area. The facility is being developed by Bhopal Development Authority under a concept-to-completion MoU with Grid

India. Land has been allotted for the project, which is estimated to cost around Rs 305 crore and is expected to be completed in about two years. The facility will control the electricity grid of India's western region.

Sharma reviewed issues related to tendering, building permissions, environmental clearance, land-use conversion and green building certification, directing officials to ensure timely, high-quality and uninterrupted execution.

He also reviewed Bhopal Smart City projects and directed officials to establish electric vehicle charging stations at major locations, including ISBT, Metro stations, city bus depots and other key points.

The Commissioner also discussed land monetisation in the TT Nagar ABD area and

directed officials to remove bottlenecks affecting development projects. Before the meeting, he inspected the B-Nest incubation centre and Integrated Traffic Management System and reviewed the e-challan system.

The administration is also focusing on integrating road safety with the city's wider mobility infrastructure. Officials have been asked to ensure that traffic management measures, ongoing construction projects and public transport infrastructure are planned in a coordinated manner so that commuters face minimal disruption. The emphasis is on creating safer, more efficient movement corridors while ensuring that major infrastructure projects are delivered within defined timelines and with adequate safety provisions.



Pigeons peck wheat from the heap of foodgrain sacks at a wholesale grain market in Bhopal on Thursday. Pioneer photo



Madhya Pradesh Congress party workers pay tributes to former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi on his birth anniversary in Bhopal on Thursday. Pioneer photo

Cooperative spinning mill up for auction

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Khargone

The auction process for Khargone's 40-year-old Jawaharlal Nehru Cooperative Spinning Mill has begun after the unit failed to recover from financial losses and the impact of a global slowdown. The National Cooperative Development Corporation (NCDC) has scheduled the auction for September 23 after dues of Rs 24.16 crore, including interest, remained unpaid.

The mill had reportedly earned a profit of Rs 25.56 crore in 2023-24 but subsequently slipped into losses. It was shut down in December 2025, leaving more than 500 employees without work. Investments of the mill's shareholders have also remained locked up.

Mill workers and employees have approached the Labour Court and are seeking nearly Rs 1 crore in pending dues, including gratuity and bonus.

The Jawaharlal Nehru Cooperative Agricultural Produce Processing Society Limited operates the spinning mill. The society was initially headed by cooperative leader Subhash Yadav, followed by his wife Damayanti Yadav. Former Union minister Arun Yadav is currently its chairman.

The society also has outstanding dues to Union Bank of India and NABARD. A demand of Rs 20.97 crore was raised on May 6, 2025. NCDC subsequently took possession of the mill on August 25, 2025. By July 16, 2026, the outstanding amount had increased to Rs 24.16 crore, including interest.

The property is spread across 19.25 acres and will be auctioned in two parts. NCDC has fixed reserve prices of Rs 4.25 crore and Rs 3.83 crore for the two lots respectively. The auctioned assets will include land, buildings and machinery.

The mill's managing director Deepak Katti confirmed the proposed auction process. NCDC Regional Director Inderjit Kaur has issued the auction notice, setting September 23 as the auction date.

The proposed auction has raised concerns among workers and shareholders, who are facing uncertainty over their pending payments and investments following the closure of the mill. The sale process is now expected to determine the future of the mill's assets while efforts to recover outstanding dues

Police probe four-year rape, conversion claims

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Bhopal

Police are investigating allegations that a woman was sexually assaulted for around four-and-a-half years and pressured to convert to Islam in the Piplani area, after a video surfaced showing Bajrang Dal activists taking the accused, Adil, into custody in the presence of police.

The video reportedly shows activists entering a flat with police personnel and taking Adil into custody. It also shows some activists allegedly assaulting him while police personnel appear to intervene. Police are examining the circumstances surrounding the incident and the assault.

The case came to light on August 17 after the woman

lodged a complaint against Adil. She alleged that he sexually exploited her on the promise of marriage and later pressured her to embrace Islam and offer namaz.

According to police, the woman works as a beautician and was already facing marital issues when she came in contact with Adil, a resident of Rajgarh, through Instagram. Their conversations reportedly grew over time, following which she alleged that Adil promised to marry her and established a relationship with her.

Police said Adil is reportedly already married. Investigators are examining the nature of his relationship with the woman, including their communications and any promises allegedly made regarding marriage.

MIC member hits out at officials

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Bhopal

Bhopal Municipal Corporation MIC member Chhaya Thakur has questioned the functioning of civic officials, alleging that she has not been provided adequate information by officers despite completing four years as a member of the Mayor-in-Council. Thakur, who handles the Urban Poverty Alleviation Department in the city government, raised the issue during the Bhopal Municipal Corporation council meeting on Wednesday while responding to a question from Congress councillor Yogendra Singh Guddu Chauhan regarding the alleged Sambal scam. Thakur declined to provide an answer, saying departmental officials had not

briefed her on either the question or the matter. She said she was not given information about the scheme or the alleged irregularities related to the Sambal scheme and suggested that the Mayor or other officials provide the response.

Following her remarks, Mayor Malti Rai responded to the question, while opposition councillors strongly questioned officials over the issue. Thakur said she had repeatedly asked departmental officials to hold review meetings but received no response. She said that as the head of the department, an MIC member should be provided with all relevant information concerning its functioning.

Thakur was inducted into the MIC on September 22, 2022.

Yadav pushes crop diversification for farmers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE n Bhopal

Chief Minister Dr Mohan Yadav has called upon farmers to adopt new technologies, crop diversification, horticulture and animal husbandry to increase agricultural incomes and create new avenues of employment and prosperity in rural areas.

Addressing the Balaram Agriculture Festival in Ashoknagar virtually from Samatva Bhawan in Bhopal, Yadav said technological advancement and innovation were opening new opportunities in agriculture. He urged farmers to supplement traditional farming with dairy production and fish farming to multiply their income.

Praising Ashoknagar farmers, the Chief Minister said they were setting an example for farmers across Madhya Pradesh through their hard work. He highlighted the district's globally recognised Chanderi sarees and the strong demand for its Sharbati wheat.

Yadav said farmers in Ashoknagar were increasingly adopting horticultural crops such as coriander and rose. Despite limited rainfall, farmers had expanded paddy cultivation using DRS technology, turning a challenge into an opportunity. Crop diversifica-

tion had also increased the area under gram and lentil cultivation.

The Chief Minister said farmers, women, the poor and youth were among the government's key priorities. He compared the contribution of farmers in fields with that of soldiers guarding the country's borders, saying both serve the nation.

He said the state government was working to make farming more profitable by improving electricity, irrigation and road connectivity to farms. Farmers would receive four times the compensation for acquisition of agricultural land, he added.

Yadav said the government was working to increase the state's share of milk production from 12 to 20 per cent and was also taking steps to provide adequate electricity to farmers during the daytime in the coming months. Subsidised electricity pumps of five, seven and 10 horsepower are being provided to support irrigation.

He said government initiatives, including Ladli Behna and Kisan Samman Nidhi, had contributed to improving household incomes and livelihoods. The government was also strengthening schools to support the next generation of farming families.

WCR signs MoU for staff banking

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE n Jabalpur

West Central Railway (WCR), Jabalpur headquarters, and Bank of India signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) on Thursday to provide improved banking services to railway officers, employees and pensioners under the Railway Salary Package.

The agreement was signed at the WCR headquarters in the presence of senior railway officials. Under the MoU, Bank of India will provide information about various banking facilities and benefits available to serving railway employees, officers and pensioners through the Railway Salary Package.

The initiative is aimed at making banking services more convenient and accessible for railway personnel and pensioners while supporting their financial empowerment.

The agreement is part of West Central Railway's ongoing efforts to improve welfare measures and provide enhanced facilities to its employees and pensioners. Officials from the Personnel Department and Bank of India participated in the signing ceremony. The railway administration said it would continue to take initiatives aimed at improving services and welfare facilities for its workforce and pensioners.

Temporary power connections for pandals

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Bhopal

With Ganeshotsav and other festivals approaching, power distribution companies in Madhya Pradesh have made arrangements to provide temporary electricity connections to religious pandals and tableaux.

The Energy Department has urged festival committees and consumers to obtain temporary connections online before installing electrical decorations at Ganeshotsav pandals and tableaux. Organisers have been advised to apply through the concerned power company's portal, clearly mentioning the connected electrical

load and submitting the test report of a licensed electrical contractor.

Wiring and electrical work must also be carried out only by licensed contractors. Applicants are required to deposit the prescribed security amount and estimated electricity consumption charges in advance and obtain a receipt for the temporary connection. A laminated copy of the receipt must be displayed prominently at the pandal or tableau.

The department said temporary connections will be metered and electricity bills will be charged at the applicable domestic tariff for temporary connections. Organisers

have also been directed not to use electrical load beyond the sanctioned limit and to strictly follow safety norms.

The department warned that unauthorised electricity use could attract legal action under the Electricity Act, 2003 against both the user and the contractor involved. The contractor's licence may also be cancelled. Officials cautioned that excessive electrical load could damage transformers and increase the risk of accidents, while overloading the distribution system could also lead to power disruptions. Consumers can contact the electricity companies' toll-free number 1912 for further information.

M3M takes VyaPower programme digital

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

PM3M Foundation has announced the digital expansion of its VyaPower Entrepreneurship Development Programme (EDP) with the launch of a dedicated Learning Management System (LMS), aimed at making structured entrepreneurship education accessible to aspiring entrepreneurs and grassroots communities across India.

Announced on World Entrepreneurship Day, the digital platform is being developed with support from Fundink and represents the next phase of VyaPower, an ini-

tiative designed to help individuals turn aspirations and livelihood activities into sustainable enterprises.

The LMS will offer self-paced entrepreneurship training that learners can access anytime and from anywhere. The digital format is intended to address barriers related to geography, time and limited access to conventional classroom-based programmes, particularly for women and youth in rural and underserved communities.

VyaPower focuses on practical entrepreneurship development rather than classroom learning alone. Its curriculum covers entrepreneurial mindset, identification of business opportunities, business

planning, customer and market understanding, costing and pricing, financial management, marketing and branding, digital opportunities, and strategies for managing and scaling enterprises.

The programme has already completed a capacity-building phase, including a Training of Trainers programme aimed at developing a pool of facilitators who can take entrepreneurship education deeper into communities.

With the LMS, the organisation plans to standardise and digitise the existing learning framework while expanding its reach and enabling systematic learner engagement and progress tracking.

Civic body to deploy machines for fresh waste

UMESH NIGAM n Bhopal

The Bhopal Municipal Corporation is preparing to deploy machines on rent for the disposal of fresh waste generated in the city every day. The initiative is expected to cost nearly Rs 4.75 crore and is aimed at strengthening the city's waste-processing capacity.

Bhopal generates around 800 to 900 tonnes of waste daily. The waste includes plastic and other materials and is collected before being taken to designated processing facilities. With the continuous generation of fresh waste, the civic body is now looking at additional machinery to ensure faster disposal and prevent further accumu-

lation.

The move comes amid a major legacy-waste problem. More than five lakh tonnes of old waste had accumulated at the Adampur Chhawani site after earlier plans for a waste-to-energy plant did not materialise as expected. The accumulated waste remains a major challenge for the civic administration.

According to the report, a company has already been engaged for the disposal of the legacy waste. The corporation had set a target of completing the work within 330 days. The company is processing around 300 tonnes of old waste per day and more than 90,000 tonnes had reportedly been processed by the time of the report. At the current pace, the corporation expects

a substantial quantity of the accumulated legacy waste to be cleared within the stipulated period.

The fresh-waste disposal plan is being pursued separately to prevent new garbage from adding to the existing legacy-waste burden. The corporation intends to hire machinery rather than immediately purchase equipment, allowing it to increase processing capacity without a major upfront investment in permanent assets.

The civic body had earlier faced difficulties in finalising agencies because of differences over quoted rates. A proposal concerning the selected company's rates was eventually placed before the municipal council. The council authorised the Municipal

Commissioner to take a decision on the matter, following which work could proceed after approval of the quoted rates.

The new arrangement is expected to help the corporation manage the daily inflow of fresh waste while parallel efforts continue to clear the city's accumulated legacy waste and improve waste management across Bhopal.

The rented machinery will also help the civic body reduce pressure on existing waste-processing infrastructure by ensuring that fresh garbage is handled more efficiently. The plan is expected to support a more organised waste-disposal process while the administration works on clearing the older accumulated waste.

Eight trucks seized in Indore

Indore: The Mineral Department seized eight trucks allegedly transporting illegally mined and transported stone aggregate and murrum during enforcement drives in rural Indore on Wednesday and Thursday.

Four trucks were seized by the department team and kept at Shipra and Gandhi Nagar police stations. Another four trucks loaded with stone aggregate and murrum were intercepted and placed at Simrol and Badgonda police stations.

The action was carried out under the direction of the district administration as part of the ongoing drive against illegal mineral extraction, transportation and storage.



Women in an exhibition cum sale 'Rakhi Runway-2026' during Shravan Mahotsav and ahead of Raksha Bandhan festival, at Manas Bhawan in Bhopal on Thursday. Pioneer photo

IN FOCUS



A lime butterfly collects nectar from red jungle geranium flowers at Nanoor in Birbhum district, West Bengal on Thursday

Yogi pushes industry-ITI link for skilled youth jobs in UP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Lucknow

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Thursday directed officials to strengthen links between industrial units and Industrial Training Institutes (ITIs), align courses with industry requirements and promote apprenticeships and on-the-job training to expand employment opportunities for skilled youth.

Reviewing the action plan of the Department of Vocational Education, Skill Development and Entrepreneurship, Adityanath said regular employment fairs should be organised at every divisional headquarters, and skill development should be linked not only to domestic



jobs but also to global employment opportunities. "Skill development should also be linked with global opportunities along with employment," he said, stressing the need for continuous dialogue between ITIs and industries.

According to a press statement, the chief minis-

ter also directed officials to operationalise the Centre for Innovation, Invention, Incubation and Training (CIIT) in Gorakhpur, Muzaffarnagar and Bareilly at the earliest. He said they should be developed as centres of excellence for modern technology and industry-based training.

The meeting was informed that 150 Government ITIs are being upgraded with the support of Tata Technologies, while the process of upgrading another 62 ITIs is underway. Advanced skill laboratories have also been established in 37 Government ITIs with industry support.

Emphasising the role of instructors in ensuring quality training, Adityanath directed officials to expedite their selection and make provisions to give selected instructors weightage in regular appointments based on their experience and work. Officials said the selection process for 2,406 instructor posts had been completed and more than 2,200 selected instructors had already joined duty.

Five injured in firecracker unit blast in West Bengal



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Kolkata

At least five people, including a woman, were injured in a blast at a firecracker unit in West Bengal's South 24 Parganas district on Thursday, police said.

The explosion took place at the factory in Champahati area around noon, following which a fire broke out at the unit, a senior officer said.

Two of the injured were stated to be in critical condition, while three others were treated at a nearby hospital and later discharged, officials said. A probe has been launched to ascertain the exact cause of the blast and verify whether the unit had the requisite licence and was following safety norms, the officer said.

According to locals, firecracker-making activities were being carried out in a makeshift structure on a plot some distance from a residential area when the explosion took place.

The exact cause of the blast is yet to be ascertained.

Tension gripped the area after residents protested, alleging that fire brigade personnel reached the spot late.

A large police contingent was deployed to control the situation. Additional SP of Baruipur Police District Atish Biswas was also present at the site.

The blast left the structure largely destroyed, with its tin roof and other parts collapsing. Burnt bamboo and other material lay scattered around the site. Trees in the surrounding area were also damaged.

"We are investigating the circumstances leading to the explosion and are also verifying whether firecrackers were being manufactured there illegally. A detailed investigation has been initiated," the policeman said.

Police from Baruipur police station are examining whether the unit had the necessary permissions and whether safety regulations were being followed.

Incidentally, Wednesday's incident comes months after a blast at a firecracker unit in Champahati in January claimed one life.

Several illegal firecracker-making units across South 24 Parganas, North 24 Parganas, Paschim Medinipur and Nadia districts have witnessed blasts in the past.

Notices issued to 1,268 drivers in Maharashtra over lack of working knowledge of Marathi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Mumbai

Notices were issued to 1,268 commercial passenger vehicle drivers — mainly auto rickshaw and taxi drivers — for not having adequate knowledge of Marathi on the first day of State-wide checking on Thursday, Maharashtra Transport Minister Pratap Sarnaik said.

The notices were issued by the Regional Transport Offices (RTOs) across the state, and these drivers were given one month to acquire the required working knowledge of the state's primary language, failing which their



badges will be suspended for three months, the minister said.

A total of 8,217 drivers were tested till Thursday evening, including 3,995 in the Mumbai Metropolitan

Region (MMR), Sarnaik stated in a release.

In the MMR, 604 drivers were found to be lacking working knowledge of Marathi. In the rest of the state, 4,222 drivers were

tested and 664 were issued notices, the minister said.

The checking drive will continue until September 30, he said.

"Possessing working knowledge of Marathi is not merely a matter of following rules but is also about the convenience and safety of passengers," the minister said. After announcing in May that basic proficiency in Marathi is compulsory, the state Government introduced a course in Marathi for the benefit of non-Marathi drivers. It had also set a deadline of August 15 for them to learn Marathi. Drivers were put through a

16-question test during Thursday's checking drive.

"Mala CNG bharayche aahe. Thode thambave lage!" (I need to fill up with CNG, we'll have to stop for a while); "majhi rickshaw/taxi sharing-chi aahe" (my auto/taxi is a shared one); and "*meter chalu kele aahe*" (have started the meter) were among the responses that officials expected from the drivers. A senior RTO official said the questionnaire was based on the Marathi language training imparted to taxi and autorickshaw drivers by the Konkani Sahitya Parishad, which ended on Independence Day.

According to RTO officials, the questions deal with situations that drivers encounter in their daily work. They include asking passengers where they want to go, understanding directions, and communicating about fares, meters, routes and taxi or autorickshaw stands.

"If after one month they are still unable to answer the questions satisfactorily, their badge will be suspended for three months. They will again be given a month to learn the language. This action will continue," said an RTO inspector conducting the checking at Dadar in central Mumbai.

High court bench for Ladakh approved; Govt reaffirms commitment to constitutional safeguards

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

The Union Cabinet has decided to establish a high court bench in Ladakh, a move aimed at improving access to justice in the Union Territory, Home Minister Amit Shah said on Thursday, reaffirming the Centre's commitment to ensuring constitutional safeguards and the all-round development of the region.

Ladakh Lt Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena welcomed the "historic decision" and expressed sincere gratitude to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the home minister.



Shah announced the decision in a post on X, saying the bench of Jammu and Kashmir High Court would significantly enhance access to justice for people living in the remote and geographically challenging

areas of Ladakh by reducing the time required to get legal services.

"The Union Cabinet, under the leadership of the PM Shri @narendramodi ji, has decided to set up a bench of the High

Court of Jammu and Kashmir in Ladakh. This will significantly enhance access to justice for citizens living in remote areas of Ladakh by reducing the time required to avail themselves of the legal services they are entitled to.

"The Government is fully committed to the all-round development of Ladakh and to ensuring constitutional safeguards," the home minister said. Officials said the establishment of a high court bench is expected to address a long-standing demand for easier and faster access to the higher judiciary for people in Ladakh.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Longowal

SAD MP Harsimrat Kaur Badal on Thursday targeted the AAP Government and appealed to the people of Punjab to end the "remote control rule" of the state from Delhi once and for all.

"Punjab is for Punjabis," the former Union minister said, adding that bringing peace and communal harmony, removing gangster rule and ending the scourge of drugs would be the top-most priority of the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) once it forms the



Government.

Referring to the recent attack on SAD president Sukhbir Singh Badal in Nanded in Maharashtra, she said her husband would never be cowed

down by the "cowards" who had attacked him twice.

Kaur was addressing a party conference held here to commemorate the 41st martyrdom anniversary of Sant Harchand Singh Longowal. She also urged Punjabis to get rid of "divisive forces" that were looting the state and destroying the future of its youth. Urging the people to consider why Sukhbir Badal was being attacked in 'Gurughar', she said that "it is clear this is being done by cowards who have become stooges of Governments".

She said SAD had always put peace and communal harmony, and development of the state first and this was not to the liking of its opponents who wanted to split the party by encouraging fringe elements.

Asserting that the murderous attack on the SAD president while he was in the precincts of a gurdwara was against the principles of Sikhism, she said, "Yes, as a wife and a mother, I did get scared for a moment, but today I can strongly look you in the eyes and assert we are all not scared and never will be."

FROM PAGE - 1

the Shravani Mela in Deoghar, but the termination of their services caused inconvenience to the general public here.

Advocates Indrajit Sinha, Amritansh Vats, Perna Jhunjhunwala, and PAS Pati presented arguments on behalf of the petitioners.

Representing petitioners advocate Amritansh Vats said, "11th to 13th JPSC and Food Safety Officer matters were before the court. Hearing the matter, the court found prima facie that the order is wrong. The court has stayed the order for now."

Sonam Kumari and Deepmala had challenged the cancellation of the 11th to 13th JPSC results, while Saurav Singh challenged the decision related to the Food Safety Officer recruitment.

Kumari stated in her petition that she joined the position after leaving a job elsewhere. She received her appointment letter on November 24, 2025, and completed training. In the interim, the Government issued a notification on August 18 cancelling the appointments. The petitioner requested the court to quash the cancellation order.

Based on findings from the CID probe, the State Government announced late on August 18 the cancellation of all examinations involving TDPL—the agency which conducted the examination. Additionally, an investigation was announced regarding potential irregularities in all recruitment exams held since 2014.

JMM MP Mahua Maji said, "In the initial talks with students, CM had accepted several of their demands. He did not want to accept one due to this apprehension - that exactly this could happen, it would have appeared that injustice was being done to some others. Perhaps he had this apprehension. And maybe that is why there was a delay (in decision-making). But there was so much pressure and a few people were doing politics over this; they were not trying to understand things. It is true that those who are already in service might have felt injustice being done. Let's see what happens now..."

Almora retreat cancels naked yoga course

"The police contacted the hotel owner during the inquiry. He said that he was also unaware of the details of the proposed event and how it was being organised," Ghodke said. Following discussions with the owner, the programme was cancelled, he added.

The retreat owner Piyush Kumar confirmed the

cancellation. "The naked yoga programme has been cancelled," he said. Kumar said that the organiser had also been informed that no activity violating the decency and traditions of Uttarakhand would be allowed at the property.

The development comes days after details of the proposed programme surfaced online. According to the organiser's website, the course was scheduled from October 1 to 30 and included daily yoga practice and study, a tantra yoga manual, certification, food, accommodation, ceremonies and excursions.

The organiser, Carla Zurcher, who uses the name Yogini Kamadevi, is from England and had earlier confirmed that she was organising the programme. The programme was advertised for fees ranging from \$3,300 to \$5,700 with a 20 per cent deposit required. Almora district magistrate Anshul Singh had earlier said that neither the retreat nor the organisation had approached the administration for permission. He had directed police to verify the event and the cyber cell to investigate related social media posts.

Ram temple faces fresh scrutiny

On his recommendation, the main construction contract went to Larsen & Toubro (L&T). Misra also chose Design Associate, a Noida-based firm led by Jai Kaktikar, for design and related work. Rai claims that Misra selected the committee members himself and that some of them visited Ayodhya only once or twice in six years. In contrast, former NBCC Chairman Anoop Mittal attended meetings regularly with Misra.

Rai said that even though construction decisions were made in meetings, changes were often made afterwards, and Misra's preferences usually took priority. He also claimed that Misra's choices were favoured when selecting people and companies for the project. Rai said suggestions from other committee members were often ignored or not taken seriously.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi laid the Ram Temple's foundation stone in August 2020. Since then, the trust and the construction committee led by Misra have overseen the project. L&T has handled the main construction, while other chosen firms have managed design and architecture.

Rai's resignation itself followed the reported theft of offerings from the temple complex, an incident that drew public attention and prompted administrative action within the trust. His decision to quit the general secretary's post on June 26, and the formal acceptance of that resignation on July 6, set the stage for the subsequent release of the detailed letter.

Trust officials have not yet responded to the specific claims in the nine-page letter. Nripendra Misra, who previously held important administrative roles, including Principal Secretary to the Prime Minister, has kept a low profile regarding the construction committee's daily work. The trust is still overseeing the remaining work at the site, while large numbers of devotees have been visiting the temple since its consecration in January 2024.

Allegations, if pursued further, could prompt closer scrutiny of the decision-making processes that guided the multi-core project. For now, Rai's left these allegations are investigated further, they could lead to more scrutiny of how decisions were made in this major project. For now, Rai's letter records his perspective on how the construction committee was formed, how contracts were awarded, and how much input different members had during the six years of building.

Observers point out that the trust's 15 members include religious leaders, administrators, and technical experts. Many will be watching to see how the trust responds, given the national importance of the Ayodhya temple project. Spiritual and architectural achievements raise questions of governance and transparency within the trust that managed Ram Mandir construction.

A workplace shooting in Lucknow opens a trail...

The claims in the message have not been independently confirmed. Soon after the shooting at the bank, Pragya Mishra posted on social media to express concern after hearing about the incident. Police recovered weapons from the second crime scene. They are still investigating the exact movements between the two locations, the couple's marital history, and any other possible factors.

Talks on water crises, delimitation dominate southern council meet

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
n New Delhi/Chennai

In a high-stakes session underscoring the immediate need for coordinated action, Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday chaired the 31st Southern Zonal Council meeting near Mahabalipuram in Tamil Nadu. The session focused on the urgent need for coordinated action. Chief ministers and senior officials from the southern states discussed long-standing crises that need quick solutions, including inter-state water disputes that threaten farmers' livelihoods.

The meeting addressed concerns about how parliamentary delimitation could affect the region's political influence. Leaders also discussed delays in justice for crimes against women and children, as well as ongoing funding problems that could harm the South's economy.

Education policy bottlenecks, critical infrastructure gaps and unresolved issues from the Andhra Pradesh Reorganisation Act. The meeting also addressed problems in education policy, infrastructure gaps, and unresolved issues from the Andhra Pradesh Reorganisation Act. Held at Taj Fisherman's Cove in Kovalam and hosted by the Tamil Nadu Government, the event brought together leaders who agreed these problems need immediate attention.

The Southern Zonal Council, created in 1956, is the main advisory group for Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Telangana, and the Union Territories of Puducherry, Andaman and Nicobar Islands, and Lakshadweep. Amit Shah chaired the meeting, with Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay as vice-chairman.



Union Home Minister Amit Shah, center, Tamil Nadu CM C Joseph Vijay, fourth left, Andhra Pradesh CM N Chandrababu Naidu, fourth right, Karnataka CM DK Shivakumar, third left, Keralam Chief Minister VD Satheesan, third right, and others during the 31st meeting of the Southern Zonal Council (SZC), in Mahabalipuram in Chengalpattu district, Tamil Nadu

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Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar, Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu, and Kerala Chief Minister VD Satheesan attended in person.

Telangana was represented by Deputy Chief Minister Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka, as Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy was abroad. Senior ministers and officials from both the states and the Central Government also took part evening, at the venue, the Tamil Nadu chief minister formally welcomed the Union Home Minister amid the gravity of the agenda. Water security occupied centre stage as leaders pressed for rapid movement on disputes that continue to fuel tension and uncertainty.

The Cauvery water-sharing agreement between Karnataka and Tamil Nadu, and the proposed Mekedatu dam, were highlighted as urgent issues. Shivakumar said the project would benefit farmers in both states and Puducherry, and called for joint action soon.

Leaders also raised safety and operational concerns about the Mullaperiyar dam and unresolved Krishna River issues, saying they need quick

technical and political solutions.

Naidu stressed the importance of accelerating the Godavari-Cauvery river-linking plan to secure additional water and prevent future shortages in the South. Tamil Nadu officials repeated the need to protect existing rights and improve daily coordination between states. The issue of delimitation was also seen as urgent.

Shivakumar asked the council to recommend that the Union Government use the 1971 Census as the basis for redrawing constituencies, maintain the Lok Sabha at 543 seats for the next 25 years, and include women's reservation in this plan. Southern leaders warned that using newer population data could weaken the region's voice in Parliament and called for clear protections.

Participants said Fast Track Special Courts must be improved to speed up investigations and trials for rape and related crimes against women and children. They discussed gaps in how these courts work and called for more support so they can operate fully.

States asked for a larger share of resources, citing the

South's large contribution to national GDP and warning that insufficient funding could slow growth and undermine public services. Education issues were also discussed, with Tamil Nadu asking for more flexibility in medical admissions beyond the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test and pushing for a quick solution.

Leaders also looked at urgent needs in industrial investment, logistics, power grid connections, disaster readiness, and tourism infrastructure. They noted that unresolved issues arising from the Andhra Pradesh Reorganisation Act and border coordination between Tamil Nadu and Karnataka require prompt administrative action.

During the four-hour meeting, leaders from both ruling and opposition states agreed that urgent action is needed. Although the council's recommendations are advisory, everyone recognised that unresolved issues over water, representation, and resources could harm regional stability and national progress. Officials said follow-up actions would start right away.

Shah visits West Bengal to review border issues

SAUGAR SENGUPTA n Kolkata

In what was being viewed as an enhanced effort to ensure peaceful law and order situation in view of recent socio-political developments an additional 50 companies of central forces were being deployed in West Bengal.

The forces that were likely to come in 3-4 days' time would double the existing post poll deployment from 50 to 100 companies.

Though there was no official statement from any quarter sources in the State Government said that the additional forces were being deployed in view of the coming festive seasons.

The central forces comprising jawans of Central Armed Police Force, Seema Suraksha Bal and Border

Security Force would "assist the State police in maintaining law and order during the festive season and would be distributed in all the 32 police districts including Kolkata," sources said refusing to comment on any intelligence input about any possible law and order issues during the Durga Pujas.

The decision o9enhanced deployment of central forces comes in tandem with the visit of Union Home Minister Amit Shah to the State.

Shah was likely to reach Siliguri late on Thursday evening when his three-day visit to Bengal would commence. The Home Minister was likely to inaugurate a 'Law Exhibition' organised by the Union government at Kawakhali ground on Friday. Chief Minister Suwendu



Adhikari too was likely to attend the programme.

Shah was also expected to chair a border-security review meeting on August 22, sources said adding the purpose of the meeting was to evaluate the coordination among the BSF, SSB, intelligence agencies and state authorities.

His visit assumes significance in the backdrop of

rising importance of Siliguri corridor — also called chicken's neck — in view of the changing political situation in some neighbouring countries. "Chicken's Neck", an approximately 20-km wide stretch connecting rest of India with the North East is strategically important because of its proximity to neighbouring countries like Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh and China.

There will be high-level reviews of international security, an official said adding his visit was a continuation of the steps the Centre was taking to strengthen border security in the eastern side of the country. This was the second visit of the Home Minister after the BJP Government came to power in Bengal.

8 hurt as ABVP, Left students fight in Jadavpur University campus

SAUGAR SENGUPTA n Kolkata

All hell broke loose in and around the elite Jadavpur University (JU) campus following clashes between the supporters of Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) and Left students' wings including the CPI(M) students' arm Students Federation of India.

The clashes that started during the midnight intervening Wednesday and Thursday and continued intermittently on Thursday left several supporters of both sides injured, police said. None had so far been arrested.

According to sources the ruckus started when alleged ABVP supporters entered the JU campus to protest against an ongoing meeting of — a defunct — Students' Governing Body asking how the Left wing students' unions could call a GB meeting when there was no elected students' union in any educational institution of the State. Flags were set on fire and some University properties



Left-leaning student organizations, including SFI and AIDSO, hold a counter-protest banner reading 'JU Against Saffron' and shout slogans at the Jadavpur University campus following tensions and clashes with ABVP members in Kolkata, West Bengal on Thursday

PTI

including an emblem — crafted by renowned artist of the yesteryear Nandalal Bose — fixed on the main gate was pulled down and damaged even as supporters from both sides of the main gate indulged in sloganeering. Bottles and egg-hurling — which become a leitmotif of recent politics in the State — was resorted to even as the police had a trying time to manage rival groups locking horns ferociously.

As Wednesday night's vio-

lence spilled onto streets on Thursday with the rival groups engaging in a show of strength taking out rallies and counter rallies, local BJP MLA Sarbori Mukherjee demanded immediate arrest of the "Maoists and Leninists."

About eight students had to be admitted to the nearby KPC medical college and hospital, sources said adding both the sides were demanding arrest of the members of the rival camps.

When contacted Bengal

BJP president Samik Bhattacharya denied any BJP hand in the conflict saying, "ABVP is not a students' organization of the BJP unlike the SFI or DSO which are controlled by the CPI(M) and SUCI... so the BJP will not take any responsibility of whatever happened."

"The ABVP brought goons from outsider and tried to set JU afire last night... we want them arrested," Dipshita Dhar an SFI leader of JNU fame said. ABVP leaders however blamed the Left for resorting to violence against peaceful protest. Later Bengal Minister and a former JU student Agnimitra Paul said, "I pray for the speedy recovery of ABVP student Nikhil Das and everyone injured at Jadavpur University," adding "the ideological battle against 'Dimagi Naxals' will continue."

When contacted the Vice Chancellor of the University said, he was submitting a comprehensive report to the Government and the Governor besides setting up an inquiry committee.

Cheap antics: BJP slams Congress for posting fabricated video footage about Nitin Nabin

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

The BJP on Thursday condemned the Congress for posting "fabricated and misleading" content about Nitin Nabin on social media, saying the main opposition party has resorted to such "cheap antics" as it is not able to garner public support.

This came a day after the Chhattisgarh unit of the Congress posted on X video footage of Nabin having lunch alongside BJP cadres in Andhra Pradesh, suggesting that the BJP president was allegedly having non-veg food during the ongoing holy month of Sawan.



"Sanskari party ke adhyaksh Sawan mein...", the caption read. "Muh mein sanatan, bhashan mein sanskar... Baaki bhajpa ka aacharan samne hai

(Sanatan on the lips, talks of values in speeches... As for the rest, the BJP's conduct is there for all to see)," the Chhattisgarh Congress said on X, posting the video footage. The caption on the video footage posted by Congress on X read in Hindi: "Sanskari party ke adhyaksh Sawan mein..." (The president of cultured party in Sawan)."

Terming the video footage "completely fabricated and misleading", BJP national spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi slammed the Congress, saying it has resorted to such "cheap antics" because it is completely consumed by "despair and continuous defeat".

Congress calls BJP leaders fraudulent nationalists as Vande Mataram row rages

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

Continuing the war of words on the Vande Mataram issue, the Congress on Thursday termed BJP leaders as "fraudulent nationalists" and accused Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah of diverting attention from their failures in dealing with the people's issues.

The opposition party's attack came after Shah criticised the Congress by saying the party's decision to sing only two stanzas of Vande Mataram was anti-national and in open defiance of the law.

During a CWC (Congress Working Committee)

meeting on Wednesday some leaders raised the issue of Vande Mataram and party president Mallikarjun Kharge clearly stated the Congress position, senior leader Jairam Ramesh said.

The Congress president read out a resolution passed by the CWC on October 28, 1937 by the likes of Jawaharlal Nehru, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose, Maulana Abul Kalam Azad, Govind Vallabh Pant and Acharya Narendra Dev, on the advice of Gurudev Rabindranath Tagore, Ramesh said, describing BJP leaders as "fraudulent and fake nationalists".

On January 25, 1950, in the last meeting of the con-



stituent assembly, Rajendra Prasad announced that the national anthem would be Jana Gana Mana and the national song would be Vande Mataram, Ramesh recalled.

The national anthem comprises just one of the five stanzas of Jana Gana Mana, he pointed out.

The Congress president said great leaders such as Gandhi, Patel, Bose, Azad and Pant passed the resolution on the advice of Tagore and for 90 years the party had been singing that part as the national song.

"There can be no two ways that we will abide by the resolution of 1937,"

Kharge was quoted as saying at the meeting.

Ramesh alleged that during the debate commemorating 150 years of Vande Mataram last year, the BJP tried to create a narrative of "Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay and Rabindranath Tagore".

"This is politicisation of the issue. This is an emotional issue for the Congress, but the prime minister and home minister are looking to derive political benefit and use this to divert attention from his failures from real issues of the people, including those of the students," he said.

"PM Modi has been tried, he is now tired and should soon retire," Ramesh said.

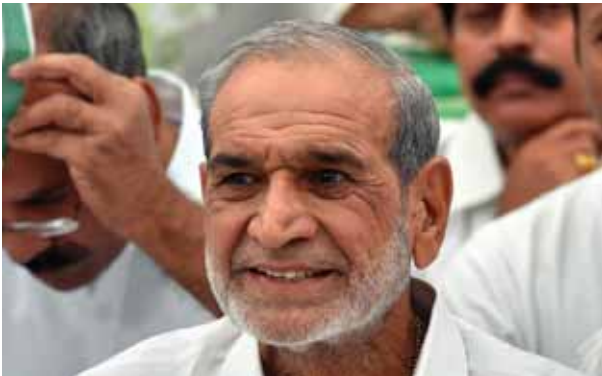
Ex-Congress MP Sajjan, convicted in 1984 anti-Sikh riots, dies at 80 in hospital

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

Former Congress MP Sajjan Kumar, who was convicted for his role in the 1984 anti-Sikh riots case, died on Thursday at 80. Kumar, who was serving a life sentence in Delhi's Tihar Jail in riot-related cases, was declared brought dead at Safdarjung Hospital. Kumar, an influential Jat leader, was identified by the Delhi Police as the key instigator in the anti-Sikh riots that erupted across Delhi and parts of north India following the assassination of Prime Minister Indira Gandhi by her Sikh bodyguards on October 31, 1984.

Supreme Court was scheduled to hear his plea on Thursday seeking three-week parole on medical grounds concerning his ailing wife. The jailed former parliamentarian had approached the top court seeking parole for three weeks, citing the medical condition of his ailing wife.

"Sajjan Kumar, aged 84 years, was brought to VMMC and Safdarjung Hospital by police with altered sensorium around 11 am. He was immediately admitted and resuscitation measures were initiated," the hospital said in a statement. "Despite provid-



Former Congress MP Sajjan Kumar has died, Safdarjung Hospital authorities confirmed on Thursday. Kumar is seen during an event at Rajghat in New Delhi in this file photo

PTI

ing all necessary medical and life-support measures, he could not be saved and passed away at 12:30 pm," it said. "He was a known case of high blood pressure and Parkinson's disease and had a history of multiple hospital admissions in the past," the statement said. He was lodged in Tihar Jail.

For more than 30 years, Kumar was not named as an accused. Interestingly, Kumar's name did not appear in the statements of several commissions that investigated the riots, including the Justice Rangnath Misra Commission and the Jain-Aggarwal panel. However, things changed in 2015 when the BJP government set up an

SIT to re-examine closed anti-Sikh riot cases.

A three-term Lok Sabha member, Kumar represented the Outer Delhi constituency and had been a prominent Congress leader. He resigned from the party after his 2018 conviction. For over three decades, Kumar faced multiple criminal cases relating to the violence, with outcomes that swung between acquittals and convictions across different courts.

On December 17, 2018, the Delhi High Court overturned a trial court's 2013 verdict acquitting Kumar in the case. He was subsequently convicted and sentenced to life imprisonment.

The riots broke out after

the assassination of former prime minister Indira Gandhi by her Sikh bodyguards - Satwant Singh and Beant Singh - on October 31, 1984. Groups of armed men targeted Sikhs across Delhi and attacked their houses and shops. Over 3,000 Sikhs were killed across India, mostly in the national capital.

Kumar began his political career as a municipal councillor from Delhi's Nangloi in 1977. At the time, he was also the general secretary of the Pradesh Congress Committee. He was among the close allies of Indira Gandhi's younger son, Sanjay Gandhi. Kumar rose through the political ranks and won the Outer Delhi Lok Sabha seat in the 1980 elections. He defeated Chaudhary Brahm Prakash, Delhi's first chief minister. However, the aftermath of the 1984 riots brought his political career to a halt after he was accused of being criminally responsible for the violence. He withdrew from public glare and continued contributing to the party from behind the scenes. After a long gap, he returned to active politics, winning re-election to the Lok Sabha for a second term in 1991, and again in 2004.

For more than three decades, Kumar faced several

criminal cases linked to the violence. The cases saw different outcomes, including acquittals and convictions by various courts. In the Delhi Raj Nagar case, involving the killing of five members of a family and the burning of a gurudwara, the Delhi high court overturned a trial court's acquittal on December 17, 2018. It convicted Kumar and sentenced him to life imprisonment.

Earlier this year, in January, a Delhi court acquitted Kumar in two separate cases concerning allegations that he had incited violence in the Janakpuri and Vikaspuri areas during the 1984 riots.

However, the acquittals did not result in his release, as Kumar continued to serve life sentences in other cases connected with the violence. In February 2025, the Rouse Avenue Court handed Kumar another life sentence in the Saraswati Vihar case. He was convicted for his involvement in a mob attack in which a father and son, Jaswant Singh and Tarundeep Singh, were allegedly burned alive.

The prosecution had sought the death penalty for Kumar. However, the court awarded him life imprisonment, considering factors including his advanced age and health condition.

PM meets Japanese defence minister, stresses on boosting India-Japan ties

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

Defence Minister of Japan Shinjiro Koizumi on Thursday called on Prime Minister Narendra Modi who outlined his vision for further strengthening the Special Strategic and Global Partnership between the two countries.

During the meeting, Modi recalled his detailed discussions with Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi during her visit to India for the 16th India-Japan Annual Summit in July 2026 and appreciated the steady momentum in defence collaboration between the two countries.

"Japan's Minister of Defence Shinjiro Koizumi, who is on an official visit to India, called on Prime Minister Narendra Modi today," a statement issued by the pPrime Minister's Office said.

Modi outlined his vision for further strengthening the Special Strategic and Global Partnership between India and Japan and highlighted the importance of India-Japan defence and security cooperation in furthering peace, stability



Prime Minister Narendra Modi during a meeting with the Defence Minister of Japan, Shinjiro Koizumi in New Delhi

PTI

and prosperity in the Indo-Pacific and beyond, the statement said.

Later, in a post on X, the prime minister said he was pleased to receive Defence Minister of Japan Shinjiro Koizumi.

"Had an excellent conversation on deepening defence and security ties between India and Japan. Our Special Strategic and Global Partnership is an important anchor for peace, stability and prosperity in the Indo-Pacific and beyond," Modi said.

The prime minister outlined opportunities for Japan to partner with Indian companies and start-ups in the defence sector, particularly for co-development and co-production under 'Make in India' initiative.

Defence Minister Koizumi briefed the prime minister about the progress in bilateral defence cooperation and reaffirmed the government of Japan's continued commitment towards deepening ties with India, the statement said.

■ States Focus ■



GURU RAVIDAS' TEACHINGS GUIDE HUMANITY, SAYS HARYANA CM

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Thursday said Guru Ravidas' vision of a society free from sorrow, injustice and discrimination continues to guide humanity, and called for his teachings of equality, service and social harmony to be put into practice.

Saini was speaking at a ceremony for the installation of Guru Ravidas' idol and inauguration of a newly built temple dedicated to him at Jadaula village in Kaithal district.

Union Minister for Law and Justice Arjun Ram Meghwal and former Rajya Sabha MP and programme coordinator Ishwar Singh were also present. (PTI)



GEN DHIRAJ SETH MEETS INDIAN ARMY VETERANS FROM NEPAL

Army Chief Gen Dhiraj Seth interacted with several Indian Army veterans in Pokhara, Nepal, reflecting the enduring bond of camaraderie and mutual respect between the force and the people of the Himalayan nation, officials said on Thursday.

These veterans had earlier served in the Indian Army and the interaction took place on Wednesday, a senior official said.

Gen Seth concluded his four-day official visit to Nepal on Wednesday during which he met the country's top leadership and discussed ways to expand the bilateral defence cooperation. (PTI)

US envoy Sergio Gor visits Ladakh triggering China watch

MOHIT KANDHARI n Jammu

After triggering a diplomatic firestorm in Srinagar by calling Jammu and Kashmir an 'important part of India', the United States Ambassador to India, Sergio Gor, landed in Leh on Thursday. His scheduled arrival at Leh was delayed due to bad weather conditions. On his arrival, the US Envoy was escorted under tight security cover to The Grand Dragon Hotel in Leh.

The visit assumes added significance because the Union Territory shares borders with China (Tibet Autonomous Region) and Pakistan.

Beijing authorities are closely monitoring the presence of a US diplomat in the cold desert region after he endorsed India's longstanding position on Jammu and Kashmir in Srinagar on Wednesday.

After a brief halt at the hotel, Gor began his tour by first visiting the Sangam Confluence at Nimmu, a



US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor's convoy arrives in Leh, Ladakh on Thursday

popular tourist destination far away from the stalking media persons. According to reports, the US Envoy also participated in river rafting along the Zaskar-Indus stretch, covering several kilometres from Tsogti.

This is the first visit of any top US diplomat to Ladakh after the region was carved out as a separate union territory in 2019 and a subsequent standoff between the Indian Army and Chinese PLA following clashes at Galwan in June 2020.

The US had strongly backed India and also condemned China's attempt to change the status quo at the Line of Actual Control in Ladakh.

During the standoff period, the US helped India with real-time intelligence and high-altitude gear for soldiers as part of a strategic defence partnership between the two countries.

Ahead of Sergio Gor's visit to Ladakh, speculations were rife in Leh about his meeting with the Tibetan spiritual

leader, the Dalai Lama, currently camping in Leh.

Till late evening, no such meeting took place. Every year, the Dalai Lama travels from Dharamshala to Leh and conducts regular religious discourses and meets followers.

Meanwhile, Vinai Kumar Saxena, the Lieutenant Governor of Ladakh on Thursday called on Prime Minister Narendra Modi in New Delhi and briefed him on the progress of key developmental initiatives.

In a post on X, the Office of LG Ladakh posted, "It was indeed an honour to call on Prime Minister @narendramodi and brief him on the progress of key developmental initiatives, infrastructure projects and the implementation of central welfare schemes in UT of Ladakh. Extremely grateful to the PM for his vision, constant guidance and support for the inclusive and sustainable development of Ladakh".

Ladakh taps 90m litres glacier water daily to irrigate 1,000 acres

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE n Jammu

Led by the Lieutenant Governor, Vinai Kumar Saxena, the Union Territory of Ladakh has successfully started utilising a massive 90 million litres of glacier water per day for sustainable water and agricultural security in Ladakh.

Previously lost as untapped runoff into the River Indus, this colossal volume of glacial-melt water from Stok village Nallah in Leh is now being directly channelised into the Igoo-Phey Irrigation Canal, catering to nearly 12 villages and augmenting irrigation of over 1000 acres of barren

land that earlier remained parched due to paucity of water in the canal.

This landmark initiative uses simple earthwork to channelise and utilise the glacial runoff, without incurring any capital expenditure. This comes as a historic step toward transforming the region's agricultural productivity and realising the vision of a Green, Water-Secure, and Self-Sustaining Ladakh.

While Ladakh is endowed with abundant glacier and snowmelt resources, vast stretches of its cultivable land have historically faced acute irrigation shortages.

The imbalance between the large volumes of



untapped, draining water and the parched agricultural lands has, for ages, constrained rural livelihoods.

Recognising this critical gap, during his visits to various villages, L-G VK Saxena ideated and spearheaded a compre-

hensive, systematic campaign by identifying such places where large quantities of glacier water are flowing down the Indus River.

To ensure that every drop of glacier and snowmelt is harnessed for productive use

Karnataka Assembly passes 3 Bills amid Opposition protest

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE n Bengaluru

The Karnataka Legislative Assembly on Thursday passed three Bills, including the Bangalore Development Authority (Amendment) Bill, 2026, which cuts by up to 50 per cent the fee for regularising properties in BDA-notified areas.

The other two Bills passed by the Assembly were the Nadaprabhu Kempegowda Heritage Area Development Authority (Amendment) Bill, 2026, and the Karnataka Town and Country Planning (Amendment) Bill, 2026.

All three Bills were passed amid protests by the BJP and JD(S), which demanded the resignation of Minister N Nagendra over corruption allegations against him.

Piloting the Bangalore Development Authority (Amendment) Bill, 2026, for consideration by the House, Greater Bengaluru Development Minister Krishna Byre Gowda said several residential layouts



had been formed through the BDA.

"Although land for these layouts was acquired several years ago, some unauthorised layouts and properties have since come up on the acquired land. We are currently unable to remove the residents from these properties, but at the same time, they are unable to obtain proper legal documents for their properties," he said.

The land had come under the control of the BDA, preventing residents from obtaining khata certificates and completing property documentation, he said.

Students now coming out to express themselves, this cannot be stopped anymore, says Rahul

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE n New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Thursday said students are now coming out to express themselves and this cannot be stopped, as he urged them to use this energy for bringing fundamental changes for the country's youths.

Addressing an event to mark the birth anniversary of his father, former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi, he said Mahatma Gandhi's vision of India to enable everyone to tread the path of 'swaraj' can be achieved only if the Government opens the doors to the young people and the country helps them walk on that path.

The leader of opposition in Lok Sabha also accused the BJP-RSS of attacking minorities, taking away the land of tribals and oppressing Dalits, saying these need to be reversed.

"The job of the Government and the country is to open the doors to your imagination and to make you feel and believe and



LoP in the Lok Sabha and Congress MP Rahul Gandhi addresses 'Hara Bhara Swaraj: A Tribute to Rajiv Gandhi's Vision' on the birth anniversary of former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi, at Jawahar Bhawan in New Delhi

have the confidence that what truth is for them... The country should help you walk on that path. That is Gandhi's vision for India, and that is the path of Swaraj.

"This is the political fight taking place in India. The students are saying we have an expression and we believe in certain things as individuals. I am very proud now that

millions of young students have understood this. That the pain they were feeling was being caused because they were being trapped and not allowed to express themselves. Now that expression has suddenly come out and it cannot be stopped," Gandhi said. He was speaking at the event "Hara Bhara Swaraj: A Tribute to Rajiv Gandhi's

Vision" at Jawahar Bhawan, where former Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot and several other party leaders and youths were present.

Noting that merely having that expression does not mean anything, he said it has to be translated into transforming the system for the youth of the country.

"How will that expression transform the education system of our country? How will that education system transform the fact that you can do whatever you want? That's really the question. How can we use this awakening, energy, now to make fundamental changes for young people going forward? This is the fight.

There is no possibility of 'swaraj' for the large mass of Indian people if one man owns every single business in this country. It cannot be done." He said Mahatma Gandhi's vision cannot exist without certain fundamental things.

"It cannot exist with an education system that is so expensive, it cannot exist with a testing system that is



Congress President and LoP in the Rajya Sabha Mallikarjun Kharge, party MP and LoP in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, Congress Parliamentary Party Chairperson and MP Sonia Gandhi, party MPs Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, KC Venugopal and others during the tribute paying ceremony of former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi on the latter's 82nd birth anniversary, also known as Sadbhavana Diwas (Harmony Day) at Samvidhan Sadan in New Delhi on Thursday

Chhattisgarh's Nari Shakti model: Women take centre stage in governance

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE n Raipur

Chhattisgarh is emerging as a striking example of women's leadership in public administration, with the Vishnu Deo Sai Government steadily increasing the representation of women officers in key positions across the State.

The latest administrative reshuffle announced on Tuesday has further strengthened this trend. With the appointment of Jayashree Jain as Collector of Sakti district and Tanuja Salam as Collector of Mohla-Manpur-Ambagarh Chowki, Chhattisgarh now has 12 Women Collectors among its 33 districts, more than one-third of the State's districts.

The latest reshuffle also saw Tulika Prajapati, already serving as a Woman Collector,

move to Kabirdham district. The development assumes significance because the Collector is the administrative face of the Government at the district level, responsible for coordinating development programmes, revenue administration, law & order and delivery of public services.

The latest appointments build on a broader administrative shift initiated earlier this year. In May, the Vishnu Deo Sai Government had placed women officers in charge of 10 districts, including Bemetara, Kondagaon, Narayanpur, Surajpur, Balarampur-Ramanujganj, Mohla-Manpur-Ambagarh Chowki, Balod, Koriya, Manendragarh-Chirmiri-Bharatpur and Sarangarh-Bilaigarh.

The message from the State's bureaucracy is



equally significant at the secretariat level. Niharika Barik, a senior IAS officer, heads the Home and Jail Department as Principal Secretary, a position carrying responsibility for one of the State's most critical admin-

istrative portfolios.

The latest reshuffle, which involved 22 IAS officers and an Indian Forest Service officer, has consequently acquired significance beyond a routine exercise in administrative postings.

Six districts ie Kanker, Mungeli, Sakti, Kabirdham, Gariaband and Mohla-Manpur-Ambagarh Chowki received new Collectors, with Women Officers taking charge of Sakti, Kabirdham and Mohla-Manpur-Ambagarh

Chowki. The posting of Women Officers to other important positions in the same order includes Roma Srivastava IAS as Chief Executive Officer, District Panchayat Sarguja; Akansha Shikha IAS as Director, Sports & Youth Welfare and Leena Kosam IAS as Commissioner, Municipal Corporation Durg.

For the Vishnu Deo Sai Government, the growing presence of women in Senior Administrative positions is consistent with its emphasis on Nari Shakti and women-centric Governance.

The State has also designated 2026 as 'Mahtari Gaurav Varsh', underlining the Government's focus on women's dignity, participation and empowerment.

What makes the Chhattisgarh experiment noteworthy is that women

officers are not being confined to departments traditionally associated with women and social welfare.

They are increasingly being entrusted with district administration, home affairs, revenue, urban development and other core governance responsibilities.

The significance goes beyond numbers. Having women in positions of authority can send a powerful message to young women across the State that leadership in public institutions is not restricted by gender.

At the district level, where Government policies directly meet citizens, the visibility of women administrators can also create new role models for girls aspiring to careers in civil services and public leadership.

The latest postings therefore represent more than an

administrative reshuffle. They signal an evolving governance philosophy in which women's empowerment is increasingly being reflected not only in welfare schemes but also in the structure and functioning of the administration itself.

With 12 of its 33 districts now led by Women Collectors and a Senior Woman IAS Officer heading the Home Department, Chhattisgarh is placing itself among the States drawing national attention for its growing representation of women in the higher echelons of governance.

For a State seeking to combine administrative reform with inclusive development, the rise of Nari Shakti in the bureaucracy could become an important part of its larger governance story.



100 DAYS OF PROGRESS

A RENEWED MANDATE BOOSTS ASSAM

Assam has completed the first 100 days of its renewed mandate with a clear focus on development, delivery and public welfare. From May 12 to August 20, 2026, the State Government, guided by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, has worked to translate its mandate into decisive action

and strengthen the foundations of a more prosperous and inclusive Assam.

The first 100 days have focused on accelerating infrastructure and connectivity while creating more opportunities for employment and enterprise. The Government has also focused on empowering women, strengthening social

welfare, and advancing key sectors such as education and healthcare.

Alongside these priorities, efforts to support farmers and rural livelihoods reflect a wider commitment to ensuring that development reaches communities across the State.

Assam's culture, heritage and identity remain an important

part of this development journey. The Government's Stated priorities seek to balance economic progress with preserving the State's distinctive cultural character. The renewed mandate also highlights the importance of responsive governance and a strong Centre-State partnership in taking Assam forward. Together, these

efforts aim to build a more prosperous, inclusive, and future-ready State. As Assam moves ahead, the first 100 days represent a period of decisive action and renewed confidence, with the Government reiterating its commitment to development and public welfare and placing the people's trust at the centre of its responsibility.

THE TRUST OF THE PEOPLE IS OUR STRENGTH; THE DEVELOPMENT OF ASSAM IS OUR RESPONSIBILITY

— HIMANTA BISWA SARMA
Assam Chief Minister

CM meets PM Modi, discusses flood recovery and development agenda

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE n New Delhi

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Thursday met Prime Minister Narendra Modi at Sewa Teerth in South Block and discussed the State's ongoing flood recovery efforts, reconstruction plans and broader development priorities.

During the meeting, Sarma briefed the Prime Minister on Assam's roadmap for the next phase of the flood response, with a focus on rebuilding damaged areas, restoring livelihoods and ensuring comprehensive rehabilitation of people affected by the devastating floods.

In a post on X after the meeting, Sarma said Modi had remained in close touch throughout the flood crisis, regularly reviewing the situation and extending assistance to the State.

Sarma said the Prime Minister reaffirmed the Centre's continued support

for Assam's recovery efforts and assured that the Government of India would stand with the State until the rehabilitation and reconstruction mission reaches its logical conclusion.

The Chief Minister also apprised Modi of key initiatives undertaken by the Assam Government during its first 100 days in office to fulfil the mandate given by the people of the State.

The discussions also covered Assam's wider development agenda, including accelerating economic growth, strengthening infrastructure, improving public service delivery and creating greater opportunities for the people.

Expressing gratitude to the Prime Minister, Sarma said his continued guidance and commitment would help advance the shared vision of a "Viksit Assam". The meeting underscored the close coordination between the Centre and the Assam Government on flood management, rehabilitation and the State's long-term development priorities.

Sarma reiterated that his Government would continue to work closely with the Centre to ensure effective reconstruction in flood-affected areas while pursuing Assam's broader development goals.



PM Narendra Modi during a meeting with Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma in New Delhi PTI

Sarma takes up Jeevan Mission, Silsako Beel rejuvenation with Union Jal Shakti Minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE n New Delhi

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Thursday met Union Jal Shakti Minister C R Paatil in the national capital and discussed strengthening water infrastructure and ensuring long-term water security in Assam.

The meeting, held at the Union Minister's official residence, was attended by officials of the Ministry of Jal Shakti and the Government of Assam.

During the meeting, Sarma discussed measures to strengthen the implementation of the Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM) in Assam and the ongoing rejuvenation of Silsako Beel, one of Guwahati's important urban wetlands. Highlighting the Centre's continued



support, the Chief Minister said the Jal Shakti Ministry has been a valuable partner in the '237-crore Silsako Beel rejuvenation project, which aims to restore the water-retention capacity of the wetland. The project is targeted for completion next year.

In a post on X following the meeting, Sarma said the Jal Shakti Ministry, under Paatil, has placed equal emphasis on expanding water infrastructure and ensuring long-term water security.

He said these priorities also shaped his discussions with the Union Minister, with particular focus on strengthening the Jal Jeevan Mission in Assam and expediting the rejuvenation of Silsako Beel.

The '237-crore project is aimed at improving the wetland's capacity to retain and reg-

ulate water, thereby contributing to flood mitigation and better management of Guwahati's urban water system.

Sarma expressed confidence that the collaboration between Assam and the Ministry of Jal Shakti would be further strengthened in the coming years.

"We look forward to extending this collaboration for the rejuvenation of urban water bodies and wetlands across Assam," the Chief Minister said in his post on X.

The Assam Government has been accorded priority to the conservation and rejuvenation of urban wetlands and water bodies as part of its broader efforts to strengthen flood management, improve water security and build climate-resilient urban infrastructure across the State.

Borders top priority for Govt: Rijiju on claims of Chinese intrusion in Arunachal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE n New Delhi

Union Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju on Thursday said border areas had been neglected in the past but were now a "top priority" of the Narendra Modi Government, as he sought to counter claims of fresh Chinese incursions in Arunachal Pradesh.

Rijiju also invoked former defence minister AK Antony's 2013 statement in Parliament, saying the Congress leader has then acknowledged India's historical policy of keeping border areas underdeveloped and that allowed China to steal a march over India in building infrastructure and capabilities along the frontier.

Antony, however, had also made it clear in the same speech that the policy had been abandoned 20 to 25 years earlier and said successive Indian Governments had since been strengthening



infrastructure and military capabilities in border areas. He had claimed that the UPA Government, then in its ninth year in office, had done the "maximum" to strengthen such capabilities.

The remarks by Rijiju, who represents Arunachal West in the Lok Sabha, come amid renewed concerns over Chinese military activity in the Upper Subansiri region of Arunachal Pradesh.

"Some people casually commented on border. Border areas are tough but @narendramodi govt is committed to border develop-

ment. I went to Maza, Galemo, Taksing areas in Arunachal Pradesh to speed up infrastructure works. Borders were neglected in the past but it's top priority now," Rijiju said in a post on X.

In a separate post, he targeted the Congress over its record on border infrastructure.

"Amongst the Congress leaders, AK Anthony Ji is very honest. As Defence Minister he admitted the Congress Govt's policy of not making border infrastructure on the floor of the Parliament," he said.

Rijiju was referring to

Antony's remarks in the Lok Sabha on September 6, 2013, when the then defence minister acknowledged that China had built significantly better infrastructure along the border and attributed India's lag to a policy followed for decades after Independence.

Explaining the historical thinking behind the policy, Antony had said, "Independent India had a policy for many years that the best defence is not to develop the border. Undeveloped borders are safer than developed borders. So, for many years, there was no construction of roads or air fields on the border areas."

"By that time, China continued to develop their infrastructure in the border areas. So, as a result, they have now gone ahead of us. Compared to us, infrastructure-wise, capability-wise in the border areas, they are ahead. I admit that. It is a part of history," he had said.

ED raids 10 premises linked to Mohammad Ali Jauhar University in PMLA probe

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH n New Delhi/Lucknow

On Wednesday, the Lucknow Zonal Office of the Directorate of Enforcement (ED) searched 10 locations in Rampur, Saharanpur, and Delhi. These searches were part of an investigation under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002, into claims of illegal land acquisition and the possible misuse of Government funds for the construction of Mohammad Ali Jauhar University in Rampur.

According to an ED, the investigation began after 26 First Information Reports (FIRs) were filed by Uttar Pradesh Police at Azeem Nagar Police Station in Rampur, along with another FIR at Kotwali Police Station in Rampur. These FIRs involve charges like extortion, cheating, forgery, and criminal conspiracy under the Indian Penal Code. Since these are considered scheduled offences



under the PMLA, the ED is allowed to investigate possible money laundering.

The FIRs and the ongoing investigation claim that Mohammad Ali Jauhar University in Rampur, led by Chancellor Mohd.

Azam Khan and others, illegally took land from local farmers and also acquired enemy property owned by the Government of India. The ED is now tracing the money trail, including how any proceeds of crime were generated, hidden, used, or turned into assets for the university. During the searches, offi-

cers seized various materials they believe are important to the investigation. These included incriminating documents, records of alleged fake donations linked to the university's Trust, and digital files.

All items were taken under the rules of the PMLA, 2002. The ED says these materials will help track the flow of funds and show if illegal money was disguised as legitimate assets. Mohammad Ali Jauhar University has already been investigated before by State authorities over related issues. The ED is now focus-

ing only on the financial side of the alleged wrongdoing. Investigators are looking into how money from disputed land deals or alleged donations was used to build and develop the university, including whether any Government funds were misused.

The searches took place at several locations in Rampur, Saharanpur, and Delhi, showing that the investigation covers a wide area. This multi-location approach is standard for the ED when collecting records from different places connected to the same case.

The Enforcement Directorate has emphasised that the investigation is ongoing. More steps will be taken as they review the seized documents and digital evidence. Under the PMLA, the agency must identify, seize, and, if needed, confiscate assets gained from crime once money laundering is proven.

238 AC EMU trains for Mumbai suburban to be manufactured on priority: Vaishnaw

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE n New Delhi

Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw on Thursday said priority is being given to manufacture 238 air-conditioned electrical multiple unit (EMU) trains for Mumbai suburban.

These will be built at three production units — Integral Coach Factory (ICF) in Chennai, Tamil Nadu, Rail Coach Factory (RCF) in Kapurthala, Punjab, and Modern Coach Factory (MCF) in Raebareilly, Uttar Pradesh. "The step has been taken to ensure the timely availability of rolling stock in line with the commissioning of infrastructure under the



Mumbai Urban Transport Project (MUTP)," a Railway Ministry statement said. "An indicative production programme provides for 120 AC EMU rakes through ICF, 71 rakes through RCF and 47 rakes through MCF, taking the total to 238 rakes," it added.

According to the ministry, Indian Railways' production units have proven capability in manufacturing modern passenger rolling stock, including air-conditioned EMUs, Vande Bharat and Vande Metro trains.

The Railway Board has approved procurement of the sanctioned AC EMU rakes on existing and proven specifications of the Research Designs and Standards Organisation and ICF, facilitating expeditious manufacturing and supply of the rolling stock.

The ministry said supply is planned to commence from 2027, with the entire sanctioned quantity scheduled for completion by 2030.

Jharkhand CM Soren vows to fight mines Bill on all democratic, legal fronts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE n Ranchi

Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren on Thursday said his Government would oppose the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, on every democratic, constitutional and legal front, alleging that the Centre passed it without taking States into confidence.

"The Centre has made changes to the MMDR Act that are highly adverse and truly unfortunate. These will seriously impact every tribal, Dalit, poor person, farmer and labourer in the State," Soren said while addressing reporters here.

The JMM president chaired the party's extended central



Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren, Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) leader Kalpana Soren and party legislators during the JMM Central Committee meeting to outline their opposition against the controversial Mining and Minerals Amendment Act 2026 Bill in Ranchi on Thursday PTI

committee meeting at Sohrai Bhawan here, where various issues, including the MMDR Bill, were discussed.

Soren questioned the Centre's decision to pass the

legislation without consulting State Governments and asked who would compensate States for the losses expected to arise from the changes. "Who will compensate for

the massive losses that are bound to occur? It appears the central Government will not even compensate for past losses," he said.

Soren said Jharkhand had already submitted a claim to the Centre for outstanding dues of '1.36 lakh crore from coal companies.

Parliament passed the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, on August 13.

The legislation seeks to restrict States' powers to levy taxes on mineral rights and mineral-bearing lands.

"We strongly oppose it, and we will also fight battles against it at the democratic, constitutional, and legal levels," Soren said.

Soren alleged that the central Government appears

far more sensitive towards developed States and feels a greater sense of accountability towards them.

"There is absolutely no sign of empathy on the part of Adivasis, Dalits, or the backward classes," he said.

Terming it a matter of serious concern for Jharkhand's future, the CM said they will continue to discuss the matter and determine future strategy.

Earlier, Soren urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to reconsider the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, saying restrictions on State levies could significantly reduce the State's fiscal space and affect its ability to address the social and environmental costs of mining.

Editor's
TAKE

Fake medicine: A crime
against humanity

The counterfeit-drug racket uncovered in Karnataka is a shocker. India needs stronger surveillance and harsher punishment for perpetrators

The recent bust of a large counterfeit-medicine operation near Bengaluru is not just another regulatory raid; it is a stark reminder that fake drugs are a slow-motion mass poisoning that demands the severest punishment and systemic reform. Karnataka's Food Safety and Drug Administration (FDA) enforcement wing raided an unlicensed facility at a farmhouse in Bidadi (Ramanagara district) and seized medicines, expired stock, counterfeit labels, packaging material and an injection-filling unit valued at about ` 4.91 crore. Officials allege that cheaper medicines sourced from other states were repackaged and relabelled to look like products of major multinational companies-including brands such as Pfizer-and then sold to hospitals and pharmacies at roughly 50 per cent below market price. Counterfeit medicines are not just another "white-collar" crime; they are a public-health assault. Patients in ICUs, cancer wards and chronic-disease clinics rely on exact dosages and sterility. Fake or substandard drugs can cause treatment failure, drug resistance, organ damage and death.

When criminals knowingly flood hospitals with relabelled injectables and critical medicines, they are effectively mass murderers operating for profit. Think of small children, old people and pregnant women being administered spurious medicines which are nothing less than poison. That moral culpability, multiplied across thousands of doses, meets the threshold of a crime against humanity. At the national level, regulators report that over 1.41 lakh drug samples were tested in 2025-26, with 3,012 declared "not of standard quality" and 283 spurious; 961 prosecution cases were filed in 2024-25 alone, a five-year high.

This itself shows the magnitude of this crime taking place across the country. In June 2026, CDSCO flagged 159 substandard drugs, and over five years more than 3,500 prosecution cases have been registered. Yet detections of spurious drugs have fallen even as prosecutions rise, suggesting either better legal follow-through or, worryingly, that many fakes never reach testing labs. The Bengaluru case exposes systemic gaps: unlicensed farmhouse units operating with relabelling lines, interstate sourcing, and deep discounts to hospitals indicate weak last-mile oversight and possible collusion. Past incidents-from fake cancer and diabetes medicines in Delhi (` 4 crore seizure in April 2024) to counterfeit antibiotics in Delhi-UP and large cough-syrup scandals-show a pattern of recurring networks with limited deterrence. Enforcement agencies deserve credit for the Bidadi raid, but the existence of such a sophisticated unit points to intelligence failures, fragmented state-centre coordination, and insufficient routine inspections of high-risk places.

Without real-time traceability, whistleblower protections, and harsher penalties, raids remain reactive. It is high time to make end-to-end track-and-trace mandatory for critical injectables and oncology drugs. The perpetrators of such heinous crimes deserve no mercy and should get the taste of their own medicine with the severest punishment.



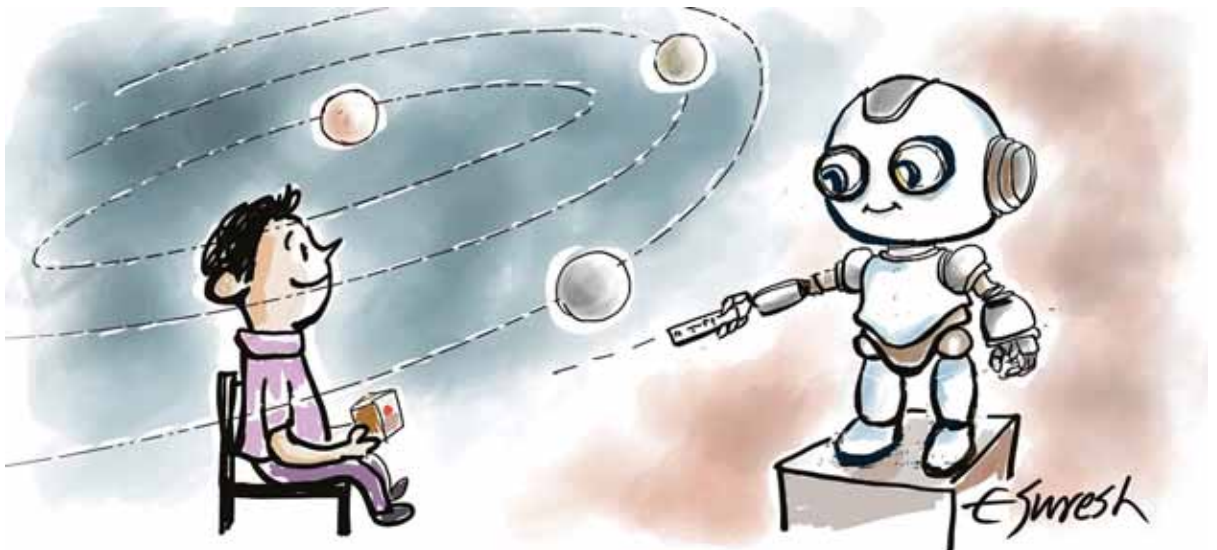
SURENDRA
KUMAR
YADAWA

As artificial intelligence rapidly reshapes the way knowledge is created, accessed, and applied, classrooms are evolving into 360-degree learning environments (students' total growth), where digital technologies, collaborative platforms, and intelligent systems increasingly influence how students learn and engage with the world. Amid this, a fundamental question emerges: should higher education focus solely on producing technically skilled professionals, or should it also cultivate reflective, ethical, and analytical minds? In India, the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 seeks to address this challenge by promoting multidisciplinary learning, curricular flexibility, and student-centred pedagogy, reaffirming that the purpose of higher education extends beyond employability to nurturing individuals who can think independently, communicate persuasively, and contribute meaningfully to society.

As learning behaviours evolve rapidly, education systems face the challenge of preparing students not merely to acquire information, but to interpret, question, and use it responsibly. In an age of smart technologies, AI should enhance human capabilities rather than replace them, making critical literacy, analytical reasoning, and the ability to ask meaningful questions increasingly valuable. Consequently, success will depend not merely on technical expertise but on the ability to scrutinise evidence critically, innovate creatively, collaborate effectively, and exercise problem-solving abilities guided by wisdom, empathy, and human values.

While integrating liberal learning with professional education, institutions can nurture adaptable, creative, and socially responsible graduates equipped to navigate complexity, exercise informed choice, and address the multifaceted challenges of society. In liberal arts education, historians, philosophers, political scientists, and sociologists encourage learners to question assumptions, examine evidence, and understand the complexities of human societies. Interdisciplinary learning fosters curiosity, critical thinking, and informed judgement - qualities difficult to replicate through technology. In an AI-driven era marked by misinformation and deepfakes, liberal education equips individuals to avoid the dangers of uncritical conformity (Hannah Arendt) in public life.

Indeed, true education brings out the innate talent of students. As the UGC underlines, knowledge, skills, attitudes and values are graduates' attributes that foster intellectual growth, creativity, and lifelong learning beyond memorisation.



By encouraging inquiry, evidence-based reasoning, and interdisciplinary learning, institutions can empower students to navigate information critically and create civic trust. By integrating the humanities, social sciences, natural sciences and technology, institutions enable students to navigate complex realities, evaluate competing claims, and exercise ethical judgement.

Its purpose is not merely to acquire knowledge but to read critically, write cogently, think broadly and act wisely.

The challenges of the twenty-first century demand more than technical proficiency; they require holistic learning that cultivates digital democracy based on curiosity and critical inquiry. Historians teach the importance of evidence and context. Philosophers sharpen reasoning and expose logical fallacies; political scientists illuminate the workings of institutions and power; literature cultivates empathy and perspective-taking, while anthropologists reveal how culture shapes human behaviour.

Together, these disciplines foster the ability to question assumptions, evaluate competing claims, and engage thoughtfully with complex realities. In an era of information abundance and algorithmic decision-making, wisdom remains humanity's greatest strength, empowering individuals to exercise ethical judgement, maintain intellectual independence, critically evaluate information, participate responsibly in democratic processes, and engage meaningfully in community action.

Liberal education equips students with the capacities needed to navigate a rapidly changing world by fostering creativity, ethical reasoning, interdisciplinary understanding, and adaptability. By integrating the humanities, social sciences, and professional disciplines, universities can cultivate sceptical and reflective minds capable of questioning assumptions, evaluating evidence, and addressing complex techno-

logical, environmental, and societal challenges by drawing insights across disciplines rather than from specialisation alone. As knowledge becomes increasingly accessible, education must empower students to think globally.

In this era of rapidly evolving technology, students now study social sciences alongside artificial intelligence, combine data science with psychology, and understand environmental challenges from scientific, historical, and social perspectives. The liberal arts seek to cultivate technical competence as well as human ability, ethical judgement, creativity, and adaptability - qualities that remain uniquely human in an increasingly automated world.

A philosopher familiar with data science engages more effectively with contemporary challenges. A policymaker who understands artificial intelligence is better equipped to govern an increasingly digital society. The ideal graduate is neither only a specialist nor a traditional generalist but an interdisciplinary thinker who can connect knowledge across fields, adapt to complexity, and approach problems with both technical competence and human understanding.

The future of education cannot be defined by technological proficiency alone. In an age when information is abundant and AI can generate answers instantly, the real challenge is cultivating minds capable of questioning assumptions (Socrates), testing ideas through debate (J.S. Mill), and making wise choices.

A liberal arts education equips students with these enduring capacities by fostering intellectual curiosity, ethical reflection, creativity, and civic responsibility. As India aspires to become a global knowledge leader, its universities must nurture not only skilled professionals but also thoughtful citizens. The sceptical mind is no longer an academic ideal; it is the foundation of innovation, democratic vitality, and sustainable well-being.

The writer is Assistant Professor of Political Science, School of Management and Liberal Arts, IMS Unison University, Dehradun

We need to stop treating reinvention as a crisis



DEEBA IRFAN
SALIM

2ND OPINION

There is a strange impatience with women as they grow older. At some point, the questions subtly change.

When we are young, people ask what you want to become. Later, they ask what you have achieved. And somewhere in the middle of life, the questions become quieter, but more loaded: What now? What are you going to do with yourself? Why are you starting again? Shouldn't you be slowing down?

I have often wondered why we think of reinvention as something that belongs exclusively to the young.

Perhaps because we have been taught to see life as a ladder. You climb it in your twenties and thirties, establish yourself in your forties, and by your fifties and sixties, you are expected to sit comfortably on whatever rung you have reached. But life isn't a ladder. It is much closer to a manuscript. And manuscripts can be rewritten. I have met women who, after decades of being mothers, wives, pro-

fessionals and caregivers, suddenly discover a version of themselves that had been waiting patiently underneath all those identities. Sometimes it emerges through writing. Sometimes through travel. Sometimes through a business, a friendship, a classroom, or simply the decision to wake up one morning and say: I want something different.

And almost invariably, there is guilt attached to it. Why? Because women have been conditioned to believe that their value lies in how useful they are to everyone else. We are taught to care before we are taught to create. To accommodate before we are taught to ask. To remember everyone's birthdays, appointments, preferences and anxieties, while quietly forgetting the things that still make us feel alive. Then one day, the children leave home. A career changes. A parent becomes dependent. A marriage enters a different phase. The body changes. Menopause arrives. The face in the mirror becomes unfamiliar. And suddenly, the old map doesn't work anymore.

This is often described as a midlife crisis. I think that phrase is unfair. Perhaps what we call a crisis is simply an awakening. There is grief in growing older. We lose people, versions of ourselves, and the illusion of unlimited time. Some losses permanently rearrange the furniture in our inner lives. But grief strips away pretence and asks what actually matters. Writing teaches us that healing is not always about forgetting what happened, but finding language for what the experience changed inside us. We live in a culture obsessed with productivity, but some things cannot be solved; they must be understood. Understanding

requires us to pause long enough to hear ourselves. We realize not every relationship has to be saved, not every rejection is a verdict, and some things simply end because they have completed their purpose. The greatest freedom of the second half of life is becoming less interested in being universally understood. Ageing should not be about becoming smaller. It should be about becoming more exact: fewer performances, fewer apologies, fewer obligations.

More truth. More curiosity. More courage to begin something without practical reasons. A woman in her twenties can reinvent herself; why can't a woman in her fifties or sixties write a book, learn to paint, start a company, fall in love, travel alone, return to university, or become someone she never had time to be?

We must stop asking women what they are doing next and ask what they have become brave enough to do. This stage is about what we leave behind-stories told, wisdom passed on, honest mistakes, books written, and the permissions we give others by refusing to disappear quietly.

I prefer continuing differently. Taking everything we lived through and allowing it to become material rather than memory. Turning grief into language, experience into wisdom, and loneliness into connection. This is the chapter where, finally, we get to write without asking anyone else what the story should be.

The writer is an award-winning, Dubai-based author exploring themes of memory, identity and emotional truth through storytelling, and is the founder of TheWriteScene.com

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RESPECT AND DIALOGUE CAN
REVIVE BILATERAL TIES

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's assurance that Bangladesh's Prime Minister would be accorded an honourable reception is a reassuring diplomatic signal. At a time when relations between the two neighbours need careful handling, such a gesture can help create an atmosphere of trust and reduce tensions.

India and Bangladesh share a common history, cultural affinities and extensive economic and people-to-people links. While differences are inevitable between neighbouring countries, they should be managed through regular consultations rather than allowing them to become lasting sources of friction.

The two sides should use every opportunity to discuss issues of mutual concern, including trade, connectivity, border management, water sharing and regional security. Constructive engagement can help

both countries protect their interests while ensuring that bilateral cooperation continues to benefit ordinary citizens.

The emphasis on an honourable reception reflects the value of diplomatic courtesy in international relations. India should continue to pursue dialogue and cooperation with Bangladesh so that existing challenges can be addressed peacefully and the relationship can move towards greater stability and mutual confidence.

Dialogue should remain the foundation of bilateral ties. Mutual respect, diplomatic sensitivity and sustained engagement can help both nations overcome differences and rebuild confidence. A stable India-Bangladesh relationship is important not only for the two countries but also for peace, prosperity and connectivity across the wider region.

RUKMA SHARMA | PUNJAB

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Potholes claim more lives

The tragic incident in which three children lost their lives after falling into a water-filled pit in Sehore district of Madhya Pradesh is deeply distressing. Such deaths are preventable and should never become routine. Authorities must act swiftly, before another family suffers further.

"Deaths due to potholes are unacceptable, the figures are probably more than those killed on border," a Supreme Court bench headed by Justice Madan B. Lokur observed in December 2018 while pursuing a statistical report on road accident deaths. Since then, much water has flown down the Thames, yet adequate corrective measures have not been made.

Earlier this month, in August 2026, the Free Press reported that Bhopal has nearly 500 potholes per kilometre. The figure is alarming and exposes the seriousness of the problem.

The Sehore tragedy should serve as a wake-up call for authorities. Roads and public spaces must be regularly inspected, dangerous pits immediately barricaded and repairs completed without delay. Citizens should not have to pay with their lives for administrative negligence. Authorities must learn from this tragedy and fix these road anomalies urgently.

TUSHAR ANAND | MADHYA PRADESH

India's test win offers lessons

Congratulations to the Indian cricket team for securing a 165-run victory in the Galle Test against Sri Lanka. The victory came largely through India's first-innings batting dominance and fourth-innings bowling performance.

The Indian batters piled up 462 runs in the first innings, thanks mainly to a brilliant 167 from Devdutt Padikkal and 84 from KL Rahul. In the second innings, Rishabh Pant's stroke-filled 66 enabled India to set the hosts a target of 372 runs. Manav Suthar was the standout performer with the ball, picking up 10 wickets in the match.

Playing domestic cricket is a prime reason for the success of Suthar and Padikkal. Moreover, India went in with a specialist spinner for the Galle Test. For Test matches, we need specialists. Gautam Gambhir must shed his inclination to select all-rounders in Test matches. India does not boast all-rounders of Kapil Dev's calibre.

As far as selection is concerned, selectors must encourage domestic players, recognise their performances and include them in Test matches when opportunities arise. The victory gave India a start to the series and 12 WTC .

S SANKARANARAYANAN | CHENNAI

The power of nuclear arms

Trump intends to call on Kim Jong Un again. Trump says Kim has 57 "very powerful" nuclear weapons. This helps us understand Trump's foreign policy: nuclear weapons command his respect.

Pakistan, a nuclear power with a troubling history of proliferation, consequently receives cautious and indulgent handling. Iran has oil but, crucially, no bomb, and this has proved a dangerous combination in the Middle East. Oil-rich but non-nuclear states have repeatedly found American interests overriding Washington's responsibility as a major power.

Russia possesses oil, nuclear weapons and a formidable military. China has nuclear weapons, economic power and military depth. Washington is careful with both. Ukraine, having inherited a substantial Soviet nuclear arsenal, foolishly surrendered it and is now paying a painful price. None of this makes nuclear weapons desirable or guarantees security. But they plainly alter the diplomatic equation. A nuclear arsenal may not make a country invulnerable, but it makes attacking it more complicated. The lesson is crude: oil makes you valuable but vulnerable, an army makes you dangerous; nuclear weapons compel negotiations. And now, Hormuz seems as good an alternative.

R NARAYANAN | NAVI MUMBAI

The long history of India’s changing relationship with nature

From the sacrifice of the Bishnois at Khejarli to the women of Chipko, India’s environmental history is also a history of people defending the ecosystems on which their lives depend. The question now is whether development can be pursued without severing that enduring bond between people and nature



BKP SINHA | ARVIND KUMAR JHA

For centuries, India’s landscapes have been shaped by communities whose lives and livelihoods have been closely connected to forests, rivers, mountains, wetlands, grasslands and wildlife. Forests, in particular, have sustained communities by providing food, fuel, fodder, fibres, fruits, medicinal plants, timber and water, while also supporting soils, water systems, local climates and biodiversity. For millions of forest-dependent communities, forests remain deeply woven into their livelihoods, traditions, customs and everyday lives.

Over generations, numerous communities across India developed customary practices to govern the use of forests, water sources, grazing lands and other common resources. Although these practices varied across regions, many were rooted in the understanding that human well-being is closely connected to the health of surrounding ecosystems. Sacred groves, community-protected forests, traditional water-harvesting systems and sustainable agricultural practices were among the ways in which communities conserved natural resources while meeting their livelihood needs.

This close relationship with nature also gave rise to a rich body of traditional ecological knowledge. Indigenous, tribal, and other forest-dependent communities developed a detailed understanding of local biodiversity through generations of observation and experience. They learned to identify plants and understand their seasonal availability, edible uses, medicinal properties, and other practical applications. Plants such as neem, tulsi, turmeric, ashwagandha, amla, giloy, and bael have long been used in various traditional medical systems and community practices. This accumulated knowledge has helped deepen our understanding of India’s remarkable botanical diversity and continues to form an important part of the cultural knowledge of many communities.

Certain trees, including peepal, banyan, neem, and bael (Aegle marmelos), have acquired religious and cultural significance in different communities and regions of India. Rivers such as the Ganga, Yamuna, Narmada, Godavari, and Kaveri have also become deeply embedded in cultural and religious traditions, with communities developing rituals and practices around these rivers.

Over time, however, this relationship underwent a profound transformation. Under British rule, forests were increasingly brought under state control and managed primarily for revenue generation and commercial timber production. The appointment of the German forester Dietrich Brandis as the first Inspector General of Forests in India in 1864 marked an important step towards establishing a centralised forest administration.

Environmental movements emerged as communities defended their close relationship with nature. The 1730 Khejarli sacrifice, when Amrita Devi Bishnoi and 363 Bishnois gave their lives protecting Khejri trees, remains a powerful example. Gandhi similarly advocated restraint, conservation and responsible consumption. The loss or restriction of customary access created economic hardship, disrupted traditional resource-use practices, and contributed to growing resentment against colonial forest policies. From the mid-nineteenth century onwards, the rapid expansion of the railway network created an enormous demand for timber, particularly for railway sleepers, bridges, buildings and other infrastructure, as well as for fuel for steam locomotives. To meet this growing demand, the colonial forest administration expanded timber extraction and brought increasingly large areas of forest under systematic management. In many regions, the colonial forest administration favoured economically valuable species and established monoculture plantations at the expense of diverse natural forests. Teak, deodar and sal, for example, were highly valued for their durability and suitability for shipbuilding, construction and other commercial uses. During the First and Second World Wars, pressure on forests intensified further as wartime requirements generated additional demand for timber,



ALTHOUGH INDIA HAS SUBSEQUENTLY STRENGTHENED ITS FOREST LAWS AND EXPANDED AFFORESTATION PROGRAMMES, CHALLENGES IN IMPLEMENTING AND ENFORCING THESE MEASURES HAVE LIMITED THEIR EFFECTIVENESS IN PROTECTING NATURAL FORESTS. MOREOVER, NEWLY PLANTED FORESTS CANNOT FULLY REPLACE ANCIENT NATURAL FORESTS THAT HAVE EVOLVED OVER CENTURIES AND CONTINUE TO SUPPORT COMPLEX ECOSYSTEMS AND RICH BIODIVERSITY.

The writers are Former PCCFs, UP and Maharashtra

fuelwood and other forest products.

After Independence, India faced widespread poverty, food shortages, and significant economic challenges that required rapid development. Large dams, mining projects, steel plants, transport infrastructure, thermal power stations, and agricultural expansion became national priorities. While these projects contributed to economic growth, they also accelerated the diversion and degradation of forests. In many cases, forest-dependent communities were displaced, often without adequate rehabilitation or alternative sources of livelihood, while wildlife habitats became increasingly fragmented. The Green Revolution significantly improved agricultural production and food security, but intensive farming in some regions also contributed to groundwater depletion, soil degradation, and greater reliance on chemical inputs.

Although India has subsequently strengthened its forest laws and expanded afforestation programmes, challenges in implementing and enforcing these measures have limited their effectiveness in protecting natural forests. Moreover, newly planted forests cannot fully replace ancient natural forests that have evolved over centuries and continue to support complex ecosystems and rich biodiversity.

The environmental movements that emerged across India were, in many ways, responses to the changing relationship between people and nature. Ecosystems have endured not only because of scientific knowledge or government policies, but also because ordinary people have regarded nature as integral to their lives and communities and shown extraordinary courage in protecting it. The Khejarli sacrifice of 1730, when Amrita Devi Bishnoi and 363 members of the Bishnoi community in Rajasthan gave their lives resisting the felling of Khejri trees, remains a powerful example. A similar philosophy is reflected in Mahatma Gandhi’s ideas, which emphasised restraint in the use of natural resources and cautioned against excessive consumption and unchecked industrialisation.

These concerns about unchecked development and the growing separation of human life from nature were also reflected in the ideas of Rabindranath Tagore. At Shantiniketan, Tagore sought to bring education closer to nature. In 1928, he introduced the Vriksharopana ceremony, encouraging people to celebrate trees and respect the environment. Decades later, these concerns found powerful expression through the Chipko Movement in the 1970s. Local villagers, particularly women, resisted commercial felling because their lives and livelihoods depended on forests. Activists such as Chandi Prasad Bhatt and Sunderlal Bahuguna helped mobilise support, while Gaura Devi and the women of Reni village became prominent figures. The movement highlighted the ecological and social importance of Himalayan forests and contributed to the government’s 1980 decision to impose a fifteen-year ban on commercial green felling in the Himalayan forests of Uttar Pradesh.

The struggle to protect nature, however, did not end with these movements. It continues today, as major development projects and resource extraction put pressure on India’s remaining natural ecosystems. The proposed Great Nicobar Island infrastructure project, coal mining in Chhattisgarh’s Hasdeo forests, and the Ken-Betwa river-linking project, which involves the submergence of forest areas in and around Panna Tiger Reserve, are a few examples of this continuing struggle. The true measure of development must therefore go beyond economic gains to account for forests lost, soils degraded, water depleted, and biodiversity diminished — costs that are ultimately borne by society and future generations.

If modern governance is to honour the legacy of those who gave their lives to protect nature, it must move beyond passive bureaucracy towards active stewardship — safeguarding native ecosystems, meaningfully involving tribal and forest-dependent communities and respecting their rights. This requires the same moral courage shown by earlier generations who stood in the path of the axe to protect their forests, so that India’s natural landscapes can be safeguarded for future generations.

Modi’s I-Day speeches: Shaping India’s future



PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH

The goal was clear: move from financial exclusion to empowerment. In 2014, when Modi became “Pradhan Sevak,” he chose not to use a bulletproof shield and instead focused on issues such as sanitation, financial inclusion, and manufacturing. The Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY) aimed to give every household a bank account. The Swachh Bharat Mission worked to end open defecation. Make in India encouraged global investment in local manufacturing, while the Saansad Adarsh Gram Yojana and the Housing for All program completed the first round of reforms.

These programs addressed long-standing poverty issues. By 2026, there were over 580 million Jan Dhan accounts with more than three trillion rupees in deposits. Direct Benefit Transfers (DBT) sent welfare funds straight to people’s bank accounts.

The Swachh Bharat Mission resulted in the construction of over 120 million household toilets, and India was declared open-defecation-free. Make in India delivered strong results: electronics manufacturing grew nearly sevenfold, mobile phone production increased 35-fold, and defence production also rose. The PM Awas Yojana (PMAY) led to the construction of millions of permanent homes. Electricity reached villages for the first time. In 2015, Modi’s speech introduced Startup India and Stand Up India to support young entrepreneurs, especially women and people from Scheduled Castes and Tribes. The One Rank One Pension (OROP) scheme met a long-standing demand from the armed forces and brought pension equality. India now has over 250,000 startups, creating millions of jobs and making the country the world’s third-largest startup hub. The focus then shifted to healthcare and space. Ayushman Bharat gave each family health coverage worth 500,000 rupees, and the Gaganyaan mission aimed to send an Indian astronaut to space by 2022. More than 450 million Ayushman cards have been issued, helping millions get free medical care. Although the Gaganyaan schedule changed, by 2026, important progress had been made with human-rated systems and uncrewed missions. In 2019, Modi’s speech focused on making water more accessible and improving military coordination. The Jal Jeevan Mission promised to bring working tap water to every rural home, increasing coverage from 17 per cent to over 81 per cent and reaching more than 158 million homes by early 2026. Creating the Chief of Defence Staff role helped the armed services work together more effectively. The COVID pandemic years were challenging. In 2020, Modi launched the National Digital Health Mission and stressed Atmanirbhar Bharat, or self-reliant India. In 2021, the Gati Shakti plan was launched as a major infrastructure project worth 100 trillion rupees, alongside the National Hydrogen Mission. Roads, railways, and logistics grew quickly, and renewable energy expanded rapidly.

India’s renewable energy capacity grew from 76.38 GW in 2014 to 288.58 GW by June 2026, nearly fourfold. Solar power saw the biggest increase, rising from about 2.8 GW to 162.15 GW, then to around 164.6 GW. Wind power went from about 21 GW to 57.44 GW. Hydropower reached 57.24 GW, and bio-power was at 11.75 GW. By July 2026, non-fossil fuel sources made up over 300 GW, or more than 54 per cent of all installed power capacity. Clean energy output more than doubled, from 191 billion units in 2014-15 to nearly 478 billion units in 2025-26. Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) in the sector reached 45.72 billion dollars, and domestic institutions invested 12.32 lakh crore rupees. From 2022, the focus moved to long-term goals for 2047. The Panch Pran pledges called for a developed India free from colonial mindsets. In 2023, Modi set a goal to create two crore “Lakshpati Didis.” By 2026, more than 20 million women earned over 100,000 rupees a year through self-help groups. In 2024, the PM Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana helped families install rooftop solar panels by giving up to 80,000 rupees per household. The program reached over 5 million households, adding almost 15 GW of rooftop solar capacity. Nearly 1.9 million families now pay nothing for electricity, and many sell extra power to earn more. Adding 75,000 medical seats over five years began to address the doctor shortage. In 2025, Modi announced the Pradhan Mantri Viksit Bharat Rozgar Yojana, a one-trillion-rupee plan to create 35 million jobs. Mission Sudarshan Chakra set a 2035 deadline for a new air-defence system. India also made progress in producing its own semiconductors, with the first home-grown chips reaching the market. GST reforms were announced as a Diwali gift.

In 2026, on the 80th Independence Day and during his thirteenth consecutive speech, Modi introduced ‘Sapta Dhara’, or seven pillars of national strength: manufacturing, agriculture and food processing, technology and innovation, Gati Shakti, defence, the green and blue economy, and soft power. He announced AI skill training for ten million young people in a year, free online coaching for competitive exams, plans for seven or eight new semiconductor plants, a 100 GW nuclear energy goal by 2047 with five new reactors this decade, a national sports talent search for children aged five to fifteen, a modern civil-defence network, and a proposal for 33 per cent women’s reservation. Modi pointed out the increase in solar capacity from 2 GW to 160 GW and the Surya Ghar program reaching five million homes. These changes are clear and measurable. Financial inclusion reached even the most remote areas. Better sanitation improved people’s dignity. Tap water and solar power became common. Health coverage protected those most at risk. Startups and self-help groups created jobs. Infrastructure and defence production grew significantly. India’s digital systems became models for the world. Renewable energy grew fourfold, solar power increased 57-fold, and rooftop solar changed how households use energy, making energy security possible.

Over thirteen Independence Day speeches from the Red Fort, Modi used the event to launch new policies. Early speeches focused on basic needs, while later ones highlighted self-reliance, technology, and making the most of India’s young people. The announced initiatives have promoted financial inclusion. They have improved sanitation, expanded insurance, and increased access to electricity. Now, these efforts are helping the next generation prepare for a future shaped by artificial intelligence. India is no longer just trying to catch up.



The author is the Resident Editor of The Pioneer

Gaumutra in perspective: Traditional knowledge and modern science stand together



JB GUPTA

Few subjects in India’s traditional healthcare evoke as much discussion as Gaumutra. Revered in Ayurveda, questioned in public discourse, and increasingly examined by

modern science, it represents a unique intersection of traditional knowledge, biomedical research, socio-cultural debate and public policy. The challenge today is to approach the subject not through ideology, but through objective evidence.

The debate surrounding Gaumutra extends far beyond traditional medicine. It now encompasses scientific inquiry, public health, and political discourse. Cow-derived dairy products are globally accepted as a rich source of nutrition. Ayurveda, India’s traditional system of medicine, has used cow-derived formulations for centuries as medicines. However, other than cow milk, public opinion often oscillates between unquestioning reverence and outright dismissal of these cow-derived therapeutic products. Neither extreme does justice to the subject. An objective assessment requires examining Gaumutra within its Ayurvedic context, alongside modern scientific evidence and broader insights from other bio-derived therapeutics. Samhita, Sushruta Samhita and Ashtanga Hridaya, classify Gaumutra among the Ashta

Mutra, or eight medicinal animal urines. Ayurvedic pharmacology describes it as possessing *Katu* (pungent) and *Tikta* (bitter) tastes, *Ushna* (warming) *potency* and *Tikshna* (penetrating) properties.

Traditionally, Gaumutra has been prescribed to stimulate digestive fire (Deepana), improve metabolism (Pachana), support the management of skin disorders (Kushtha and Twak Roga), and address conditions such as *Medoroga*, *Shotha* and *Udara Roga*. It is also recognised as a Yogavahi, a catalytic medium believed to enhance the absorption and therapeutic efficacy of herbal, mineral and metallic preparations used in Ayurveda.

Equally important is the dosage form in which it is administered. Classical Ayurveda rarely recommends the consumption of raw, untreated cow urine. Instead, it emphasises Gaumutra Ark, a purified distillate obtained through controlled vaporisation and condensation, or its use in traditional formulations such as Panchagavya, which combines cow milk, curd, ghee, urine and dung in specific proportions. Processing and formulation have always remained integral to Ayurvedic therapeutics.

Scientific interest in Gaumutra has grown steadily over the past two decades. Laboratory analyses have identified a range of naturally occurring constituents, including urea, uric acid, allantoin, hippuric acid, phenolic acids such as gallic, caffeic, ferulic and salicylic acids, essential minerals including calcium, magnesium, potassium, sodium and phosphates, as well as enzymes. These findings have encouraged researchers to investi-



gate their possible biological significance.

One of the most significant developments is research on ‘Cow Urine Distillate (CUD)’, also known as Go-Ark, as a potential bioenhancer. Research undertaken by the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR), in collaboration with the Central Institute of Medicinal and Aromatic Plants (CIMAP), resulted in two U.S. patents in 2002 and 2005 relating to the use of CUD for enhancing the effectiveness of certain antibiotics and anticancer drugs. Studies cited in the literature suggest that CUD may improve the absorption of antibiotics such as rifampicin and ampicillin, as well as anticancer drugs including paclitaxel, thereby enhancing their efficacy.

Published laboratory studies have reported antioxidant activity through free-radical scavenging, while other investigations have demonstrated antibacterial and antifungal effects against several microorganisms, such as Escherichia coli, Staphylococcus aureus, Klebsiella species, Candida albicans, etc., under controlled laboratory condi-

tions. These observations provide scientific leads for further investigation into the biological properties of Gaumutra and its distilled preparations.

Viewed in isolation, Gaumutra often appears exceptional. However, modern pharmacology has long relied on biologically derived materials for developing life-saving medicines.

Human urine has provided compounds such as urokinase and menotropins. Gila monster saliva led to the development of Exendin-4 for Type 2 diabetes. Hirudin from leech saliva, peptides from Jararaca viper venom, heparin, insulin and conjugated estrogens demonstrate the therapeutic potential of biological materials.

The distinguishing factor has never been the biological source itself, but the rigorous scientific process through which active molecules are isolated, characterised, standardised, tested for safety and evaluated through clinical trials.

The discussion gained renewed public attention in January 2025 when V Kamakoti, Director of IIT Madras, referred to the traditional medicinal uses of Gaumutra during a public address, citing its reported antibacterial, antifungal and digestive properties.

The remarks triggered immediate debate. Medical associations cautioned against promoting the consumption of unprocessed cow urine because of the potential risks of zoonotic infections and other health concerns. At the same time, supporters argued that traditional knowledge systems deserve scientific investigation rather than outright dismissal. The issue resurfaced after Prof. Kamakoti received the Padma Shri in 2026, with discussions once again extending beyond science into the

broader realm of public discourse.

The continuing debate over Gaumutra reflects differences in scientific interpretation, public perception, cultural identity and political narratives. Exaggerated claims without sufficient evidence can undermine scientific credibility, while blanket rejection of traditional formulations risks overlooking potentially valuable avenues of investigation.

Another important issue concerns methodology. Scientific scepticism often arises from advocacy of raw, unprocessed cow urine rather than standardised preparations. Concerns regarding microbial contamination and zoonotic infections reinforce the need to distinguish between raw biological material and purified formulations such as Gaumutra Ark.

Equally important is the evidence gap. While laboratory findings are encouraging, large-scale, well-designed human clinical trials remain limited. Bridging this gap requires rigorous chemical profiling, safety evaluation, pharmacological studies, standardised manufacturing and robust clinical trials.

The discussion on Gaumutra should neither be driven by unquestioning belief nor automatic dismissal. Traditional knowledge and modern science need not stand in opposition. Moving beyond political rhetoric and focusing on evidence-based investigation offers the most credible path forward. Gaumutra Ark should be evaluated through rigorous scientific standards to establish its safety, efficacy and clinical relevance.

The writer is an Ayush Distinguished Scientist at the Ministry of Ayush

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Order Order

Delhi HC grants week to Govt for response on same-sex plea



The Delhi High Court on Thursday questioned the Centre for its failure to respond, even after a year, to a petition seeking recognition of same-sex couples as medical representatives during medical treatment.

The court orally observed that when people are allowed to enter into a live-in relationship with same-sex partners, then the authorities have to make changes in the rules accordingly.

"The law recognises a live-in relationship between a man and a woman. Why will it not allow a live-in relationship between a man and a man?"

"Whenever a person chooses a path which is not a path taken by the majority, they will be targeted or looked down upon; or not looked down but will not be accepted. I have many cases where the families give them up and do not accept the relation," Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma said.

The court, which had issued notice to the Centre and National Medical Commission (NMC) in July 2025, asked why the authorities have not filed their replies yet.

"You need to tell me what your stand is. This fight is what for?" the court said. (PTI)

Narayan Rane offers to settle defamation case filed by Raut



BJP MP Narayan Rane on Thursday told a court here that he was willing to settle the defamation case filed against him by Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Sanjay Raut.

Raut, who is also a Rajya Sabha member, had filed a criminal defamation complaint against the former Union minister for allegedly making "malicious and false" remarks against him at the Konkani Festival held in Bhandup in the metropolis on January 15, 2023.

During the hearing of the matter before the Mazgaon magistrate court, Rane's lawyer Satishmane Shinde "offered for the settlement of the complaint".

However, advocate Sarthak Shetty, appearing for Raut, said that they had not received any proposal yet.

A decision on settlement can be taken only after the proposal is received, he added.

Rane had allegedly said Raut's name did not exist in the voters' list and that he (Rane), when he was in the undivided Shiv Sena, had helped the latter get elected to the Rajya Sabha.

Taking cognisance of the complaint, the Mazgaon court had issued process (summons) to the BJP MP.

Rane challenged the summons before a special court dealing with cases against MPs and MLAs, saying no defamation case was made out against him.

The special court had upheld the summons, saying Rane made "vague and unsubstantiated" statements against Raut "indicating malice". (PTI)

Delhi HC asks trial court to defer evidence in Chinese visa case against Karti Chidambaram

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Thursday directed a trial court to defer recording of evidence in the alleged Chinese visa scam case in which Congress MP Karti Chidambaram is facing prosecution on charges of corruption and criminal conspiracy.

Justice Manoj Jain directed the trial court not to record statements of witnesses till October 8. "It would be appropriate that the trial court defers recording of evidence in the case till the next date of hearing (before the high court)," Justice Jain said.

The high court was informed that the matter is listed before the trial court this Friday.

The high court passed the order on separate pleas by the CBI, Karti Chidambaram and other accused challenging the framing of charges in the case.



While Karti Chidambaram and other accused have challenged the framing of corruption and conspiracy charges on the ground that no case was made out against them, CBI has sought framing of additional charges against the accused.

During the hearing, the CBI's counsel argued that the trial be permitted to go on and the probe agency be allowed to record statements of some of the former witnesses who are old and crucial to the



Shinde faction reaping fruits of defection: Sena (UBT) tells SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

The Shiv Sena (UBT) on Thursday told the Supreme Court that the Eknath Shinde-led faction continued to enjoy the "fruits of defection" and the Election Commission granted Shiv Sena's name and the symbol to them substantially based on the legislative majority test.

The submissions were made before a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, which resumed hearing on the seventh day the challenge of the Uddhav Thackeray faction to the EC's decision recognising the Shinde-headed group as the "real Shiv Sena" and allotting it the party name and the 'bow and arrow' election symbol.

Senior advocate Devadatt Kamat, appearing for the Thackeray faction, said the Shinde group continue to reap the benefits of that defection because the symbols order of the poll panel stood on the basis of the legislative majority test.

"In this case, they have already enjoyed the fruits of defection because the matter could not be heard in time. We are not blaming anybody. But they continue to reap the benefits even today. The symbols order stands based on the legisla-



tive majority test," Kamat said. "Once disqualified, they lose their membership," Kamat said, adding that the alleged defectors had already benefited from the delay in deciding the disqualification petitions.

The bench questioned Kamat on the scope of the relief being sought. "Disqualified from what?" the bench asked.

Kamat responded that disqualification was a legal consequence flowing from the act of defection and that the court could declare the date from which the members incurred disqualification, even if consequential relief could no longer be effectively granted.

"It is a legal declaration that the member lost his membership from the date

on which the act of defection was committed," he said.

The senior advocate said that the top court, in the past, itself determined the disqualification in appropriate circumstances rather than remanding the matter to the Speaker.

He referred to the Supreme Court's judgement in a case and said that the court had previously held that the constitutional scheme under the Tenth Schedule of the Constitution could not be allowed to be undermined by inaction or failure on the part of the Speaker.

"In extraordinary circumstances, where the Speaker fails to decide, the Supreme Court can itself determine disqualification in the first instance," Kamat said. He said the circumstances in the

present case warranted a similar approach, particularly because the dispute over the party's identity and election symbol was directly linked to the legislative majority relied upon by the EC.

"The fruit of the alleged defection which they continue to enjoy today is the party symbol. That symbol rests upon their so-called legislative majority," he said.

"We are only urging Your Lordships to decide this issue — whether they have committed defection or not. If they did, one of the principal grounds on which the Election Commission awarded them the symbol disappears," he said.

He said that the speaker's order, which favoured the Shinde camp, was illegal and had a "definitive impact" on the symbol dispute. Kamat said that the EC was not justified in applying the "test of legislative majority" while the legality of the MLAs' status was still in question.

On Wednesday, senior advocate Kapil Sibal, also appearing for the Thackeray group, had argued that recognising the Shinde faction as the "real" Shiv Sena would amount to rewarding what he termed a "constitutional sin".

The Shinde group would resume its final arguments on September 2.

1978 industry definition won't apply to 2020 code: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

The Supreme Court, by a majority of 6:3, on Thursday held that the labour-friendly expansive definition of the term "industry" in its 1978 verdict shall not be considered for the interpretation of the Industrial Relations Code of 2020.

A nine-judge Constitution bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant also, by a majority verdict, held that the reference seeking reconsideration of a 1978 judgement by a seven-judge bench on the

definition of "industry" was validly made.

On February 21, 1978, the seven-judge bench had delivered a verdict on the definition of the term "industry" while deciding the plea of Bangalore Water Supply and Sewerage Board and expanded its definition, which brought millions of employees in hospitals, educational institutions, clubs and government welfare departments under the protection of the Industrial Disputes (ID) Act, 1947.

The CJ, who authored the majority verdict for himself



and Justices Satish Chandra Sharma, Alok Aradhe and Vipul M Pancholi, made clear that the "triple test",

evolved in the 1978 judgement, to ascertain what constitutes an "industry" will remain valid.

However, the "triple test" will be applied in labour-related pending cases lodged under the now-repealed 1947 ID Act.

Justices PS Narasimha and Joymalya Bagchi penned separate verdicts, broadly agreeing with the majority judgement of the CJ. Both the judges held that the reference seeking reconsideration of the 1978 verdict on the definition of the term "industry" was valid.

Don't let children face pressure over 3-language policy: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

Observing that children should not come under any kind of pressure, the Supreme Court on Thursday stressed the need to find a solution to issues arising out of the CBSE policy mandating the study of three languages by Class 9 students.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana observed there was nothing wrong in introducing the policy, but the only concern raised by the petitioners was about the manner in which it was being introduced.

"Some of these problems, you may revisit. There is no



doubt that sooner or later, it has to be introduced. There is nothing wrong with that. But how it is to be streamlined so that whatever impediments or blockades are coming up, you may find a solution to those," the bench told

Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati.

The bench said one of the aspects that was required to be considered was how to build adequate human resource infrastructure for the language options available.

"If you have chosen Class 6 as the starting point, you may consider giving a reprieve to Class 6 students of this year. You can introduce it from next year," it said.

"Another thing which needs to be looked into is where you draw the line. Whether it is Class 6, Class 4 or Class 3. You can take a call depending on the curriculum and where the choice between two and three languages is first introduced," the bench said.

It said one of the concerns was whether we consider English a native language or a foreign language.

"As the Union of India, you will also have to see that other than the CBSE, what is happening in other boards,"

the bench told Bhati, adding that it has to be ensured that the roll-out of the policy is appropriately undertaken.

Bhati said she would take instructions on the suggestions and get back to the court.

"We don't want the children to come under any pressure," the CJ said.

The top court was hearing a batch of pleas challenging the CBSE's policy mandating the study of three languages, including two native Indian languages, for Class 9 students from July 1.

At the outset, senior advocate Anand Grover, appearing for some of the petitioners, told the bench that the issue relates to three languages and that they were concerned with Class 6.

Restricting social media for children Govt's domain, says Delhi HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Thursday said banning or regulating the use of social media by children fell in the realm of the Centre's policy-making, and asked the authorities to decide on this aspect. A bench of Justices V Kameswar Rao and Manmeet PS Arora refused to entertain a public interest litigation (PIL) seeking to restrict the use of social media by children and asked the central Government to consider it as a representation.

The bench, however, refused to set a timeline for the authorities to complete the exercise. "Your views would be taken into consideration by the respondents. The stakeholders have to be consulted. Their views have to be taken, and then it is in the realm of a policy. It is not for a court to give a direction that you should ban this, or that you should ban that. Let them look into it and then pass an order," the bench told the petitioner's lawyer.

The petitioner sought a direction to the Centre to consider enacting a law or guidelines to "restrict" the use of social media by children under the age of 13 years.

It also prayed for a framework to "regulate" social



media content for children aged 13-16 years.

Central Government Counsel Nidhi Raman said the issue of restricting or regulating the use of social media was a policy issue which has to be considered by the Centre as it may require enactment of a new law.

Such a policy will have wider ramifications, and would require stakeholder consultation, she added.

The Centre's counsel submitted that the petitioner's plea can be considered as a representation by the authorities and an appropriate order can be passed.

On being asked by the court if any action was taken after an earlier Supreme Court order on the issue, the lawyer said that the Digital Personal Data Protection Act has been enacted, which also safeguards children's privacy online.

Talk to children to build bond, SC tells parents



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday told parents that instead of sending their children to too many classes like music and taekwondo, they should take out some time and talk to them.

While hearing a child custody case, a bench of Justices BV Nagarathna and R Mahadevan questioned the parents for enrolling their kids in multiple after-school activities to give them a competitive edge.

"The parents should treat them, give them good etiquette, manners -- boys especially. How they should treat girls and women, they should teach them. Parents should teach them instead of sending them to extra classes. That is how the bond will develop between the parents and the children," Justice Nagarathna observed.

On the top court's observation, an advocate appearing for one of the parties said that such classes help the child in all-around development for a highly competitive world.

Justice Nagarathna then said, "So many classes are also not good for children. Parents should just sit with them and talk to them."

"They will become better children; there will be better interaction. Instead of sending them to art class, music class, taekwondo, something else. Instead of that, you take a class with your children."

SC asks Govt to form panel in a week for ex-HC judges

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday granted one more week to the Centre to set up a panel for a uniform national policy on post-retirement benefits such as services of drivers, security and stay in government accommodations for former High Court judges while travelling.

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana took note of the submissions of Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati that the Government be given some more time to set up the panel.

"The Additional Solicitor General seeks one week to set up the committee," the bench said, adding that the matter will now be listed after 10 days.

During the brief hearing, the bench, after being told



that the Centre has not set up the panel so far, said that if it is not done, then the court itself will set up the committee.

Earlier, on July 20, the bench had asked the Centre to set up the panel within two weeks for a uniform national policy regarding post-retirement benefits like services of drivers, security and stay in government accommodations while travelling for former High Court judges.

It had also directed that the panel would have to

give its report on the issue within three months.

The bench was hearing a contempt petition filed by Justice VS Dave, President of the Association of Retired Judges of the Supreme Court and High Courts, raising the issue of security and other facilities for retired judges.

During the hearing, the CJ had questioned the adequacy of the financial assistance currently provided by some States for engaging security personnel and drivers.

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DPIIT inks MoU with PhonePe, Shell India to support startups

PhonePe

The Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) on Thursday said it has inked pacts with PhonePe and Shell India to support startups.

The partnerships are aimed at enhancing access to technology, digital infrastructure, mentorship, market opportunities, and industry networks, it said.

Under its collaboration with DPIIT, PhonePe will provide DPIIT-recognised startups with a range of benefits, including transaction credits through its payment gateway, access to the Indus AppStore, dedicated onboarding and support services, and opportunities for enhanced brand visibility.

The MoU with Shell India will focus on supporting startups operating in the energy and climate-tech sectors.

Through this partnership, Shell India will provide mentorship, strategic guidance, investor and incubator connect, and opportunities to participate in the Shell E4 Smart Energy Track.

The initiative is expected to help startups access growth opportunities, scale innovative solutions and contribute to India's clean energy transition, it said. (PTI)

India-EU trade pact clears legal scrubbing: Official

India and the 27-nation European Union (EU) have completed the legal scrubbing of the trade pact text and it will be signed this year on a mutually agreed date, an official said on Thursday.

On January 27, India and the European Union announced the conclusion of negotiations for the free trade agreement, described as the "mother of all deals", under which 93 per cent of Indian shipments will enjoy duty-free access to the 27-nation bloc, while imports of luxury cars and wines from the EU will become less expensive.

"The scrubbing is over," the official said.

Taken together, India and the EU account for 25 per cent of the global GDP and one-third (about \$11 trillion) of international trade (about \$33 trillion). (PTI)

SEBI eases FPI onboarding by allowing digitally signed PoA

Capital markets regulator SEBI on Thursday eased the onboarding process for foreign portfolio investors by allowing them to submit a digitally signed power of attorney to their custodians.

Under the revised rule, an FPI can give a Power of Attorney (PoA) to its custodian specifying its address and execute the document by using a digital signature in accordance with the provisions of the Information Technology Act, 2000, SEBI said. A Power of Attorney is a document through which a foreign portfolio investor (FPI) authorises its custodian to act on its behalf.

For an FPI, a custodian is a financial institution that

safely holds and manages investors' securities and assets. They also act as designated depository participants to process FPI registrations, clear trades, manage settlements, and report compliance to regulators.

This eliminates the need for notarisation, apostillation or consularisation of the Power of Attorney, thereby reducing the overall time taken for FPI onboarding and improving ease of doing business for FPI applicants, it added.

India's battery storage self-reliance a decade away: Report

It would take another 10 years for India to achieve self-sufficiency in battery storage as there is a huge gap between the demand and current capability to manufacture essential battery cell components, according to Wood Mackenzie.

India's domestic battery manufacturing currently accounts for less than 1 per cent (2 GWh) of its approximately 260 GWh demand pipeline from competitive tenders in 2026, the research said.

The gap leaves the country structurally dependent on

imports even as policy ambition accelerates, the research, titled 'Chasing Self-Sufficiency: Cost of Building an Indigenous Battery Storage Supply Chain in India', said.

Despite more than 226 GWh of cell manufacturing capacity announced for construction through 2035, execution delays, financial viability challenges and deep technology dependence on Chinese and Korean licensors mean India remains 10 to 15 years from a globally competitive, self-sufficient cell industry.

India has just 2 GWh of commissioned cell manufacturing capacity as of

The Pioneer

BHOPAL | FRIDAY | AUGUST 21, 2026

Local currencies cut cross-border trade costs: RBI deputy governor

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Mumbai

Local currencies will play an ever-increasing role in cross-border trade and payments as they lower transaction costs, reduce currency mismatches, and improve settlement efficiency, RBI Deputy Governor Rohit Jain has said.

Speaking at the Annual Day of the Foreign Exchange Dealers' Association of India (FEDA) last week on 'India's Foreign Exchange Markets: Getting ready for the next Decade', Jain said that by their very nature, markets are continuously evolving and parameters of their readiness are being regularly renewed according to the needs of the time.

"Our market would be ready for the next decade if it can help facilitate India's ever-

increasing engagement with other countries, absorb shocks in a non-disruptive manner, serve the smallest user as efficiently as the biggest, and embrace new technology without vitiating the trust it has earned," he said.

The deputy governor said India's foreign exchange reserves have risen from about \$38 billion in 2000 to

\$691 billion in 2026. The average daily turnover in the domestic forex market, spot and derivatives combined, has doubled from \$41 billion in FY22 to about \$80 billion at present.

Talking about drivers that will shape India's forex markets in the coming decade, Jain said local currencies will play an ever-

increasing role in cross-border trade and payments.

The Special Rupee Vostro Account (SRVA) framework for invoicing, payment and settlement of international trade in rupees has been implemented keeping in view the evolving dynamics of our international trade.

Its success, he said, will depend on commercial viability, emphasis on trade settlement in local currencies, offering market-determined rates, and strengthening confidence in the settlement ecosystem.

"The settlement of cross-border transactions in local currencies results in lower transaction costs, fewer currency mismatches, better settlement efficiency, and the ability to trade where correspondent banking is costly or constrained," the deputy governor said.

Rupee settles on flat note, higher by 3 paise at 95.70

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE n Mumbai

The rupee pared initial gains and settled for the day with gains of just 3 paise at 95.70 against the US dollar on Thursday, as the support from the weaker dollar index was negated by elevated crude oil prices.

Forex traders said while a weaker US dollar eases some depreciation pressure on the domestic currency, crude oil hovering above \$90 would continue to keep pressure on India's import bill. The dollar index fell to its lowest level since late May after the US Treasury announced that it would double its buyback operations for longer-dated Treasury bonds, pushing US long-term yields lower and reducing the dollar's yield advantage.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 95.57 against the greenback and traded in a range of 95.56-95.72 during the session. It even-

tually settled at 95.70 (provisional), higher by 3 paise from its previous close. On Wednesday, the rupee stayed almost flat, ending just 1 paise higher at 95.73 against the US dollar.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 98.61, lower by 0.22 per cent.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading higher by 2.22 per cent at \$93.65 per barrel in futures trade. According to Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst, Mirae Asset Sharekhan, the rupee opened higher on weak dollar and positive domestic markets. However, rupee pared initial gains on rising crude oil prices.

We expect the rupee to trade with a slight negative bias on renewed geopolitical tensions between the US and Iran after US President Donald Trump announced crushing economic sanctions against Iran.

Kia begins Sorento production ahead of India launch

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

Kia India has commenced production of the Sorento premium three-row SUV at its Anantapur manufacturing facility, ahead of the model's scheduled India launch on September 4.

The company has also released the first official images of the Sorento, which will expand Kia's presence in India's premium SUV segment. The model is being manufactured locally and is positioned as the brand's flagship SUV for the Indian market.

The Sorento will be Kia India's first hybrid SUV, with

an all-wheel-drive system. It will also be offered with a diesel powertrain, giving buyers a choice between electrified and conventional propulsion. The company said the move forms part of its broader multi-powertrain strategy for India.

A key technology feature of the India-bound Sorento will be Kia's AI Assistant, powered by live generative artificial intelligence. According to the company, the India-specification Sorento will be the first model globally to introduce the technology across Kia's

product portfolio. It will also mark the first deployment of live generative AI in the Indian automotive industry, Kia said.

Unlike conventional voice assistants that respond to a limited set of commands, the system is designed to

support more conversational interactions and provide access to real-time information. Kia expects the feature to enhance the vehicle's technology and premium positioning.

The first locally produced Sorento rolled off the assembly line at Anantapur on Thursday. Kia began manufacturing vehicles at the Andhra Pradesh plant in 2019. The facility has an installed annual production capacity of 400,000 units and serves both domestic and export markets.

"With the first locally produced Sorento rolling off the production line at our Anantapur facility today, we

are taking an important step in bringing this globally acclaimed premium flagship SUV to Indian customers," said Gwanggu Lee, managing director and CEO, Kia India.

Pre-bookings for the Sorento are currently open through Kia India dealerships and the company's official website. Pricing and detailed specifications are expected to be announced at the launch.

Kia India has dispatched nearly 1.9 million vehicles from its Anantapur plant, including more than 1.5 million units sold domestically and over 367,000 exported, according to company data. It operates 892 touchpoints across 407 Indian cities.

Sensex jumps 628 points, Nifty snaps 7-day losing streak

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n Mumbai

Benchmark equity indices bounced back on Thursday, with the Sensex climbing 628 points and the Nifty snapping its seven-day losing streak as easing global bond yields fueled a stock rally worldwide.

The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 628.04 points, or 0.82 per cent, to settle at 77,537.72 after four days of decline. During the day, it surged 701.43 points, or 0.91 per cent, to 77,611.11.

Snapping its seven-day falling streak, the 50-share

NSE Nifty rose by 153.55 points, or 0.64 per cent, to close at 24,231.85.

"Markets found much-needed relief after the US Treasury stepped in to

contain the surge in global bond yields, triggering a strong broad-based rebound and ending the domestic market's week-long losing streak. The intervention has dragged down the dollar, which, along with a firmer rupee and easing yield pressures, boosted attractiveness to EMs," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Ltd, said.

The recovery was widespread across sectors, driven primarily by strength in IT and financial stocks, as a cooling yield environment supports spending, he said.

Govt official asks industry to utilise FTAs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
n New Delhi

The Government on Thursday nudged the industry to utilise Free Trade Agreements (FTAs), focus on value addition, build resilient supply chains, and actively diversify export markets to boost manufacturing and strengthen the country's position in global trade.

only to China among major manufacturing destinations.

Cell manufacturing is expected to develop progressively with imported inputs over the next two to five years, while full refining capabilities will take more than ten years to establish.

India is expected to prioritise the localisation of downstream components, including containers, energy management systems, SCADA, and battery packs, over the next two to three years, supported by a 20 per cent domestic content requirement now applied to grid-scale BESS projects under new tenders.

All trade agreements which India has signed "are a door, but doors, however magnificently crafted, do not open themselves. It is the industry that must walk through them," said Additional Secretary in the Department of Commerce Yashvir Singh.

He said the industry should use FTAs to expand market access, attract investment and technology, diversify supply chains, and build manufacturing ecosystems that can withstand global shocks.

The ambition is not merely to participate in global manufacturing but to make India a reliable, competitive, and trusted partner in global value chains, he said at a manufacturing conclave.

FROMTHE
WORLD

SRI LANKA

Israel flags demonstration

The Israel embassy on Thursday expressed concern over a demonstration against a Jewish cultural site in Sri Lanka, citing a statement by a US State Department official.

The embassy issued a statement citing a statement by Rabbi Yehuda Kaploun, Special Envoy to Monitor and Combat Antisemitism at the US Department of State, who raised concern over the protest against a Jewish site in Sri Lanka.

"Concerned by reports of a demonstration targeting a Jewish site in Sri Lanka. I urge local authorities to ensure the safety and security of the Jewish community in Sri Lanka," Kaploun posted on X. The concerns followed a demonstration held by hundreds of Buddhist monks last Friday against a Chabad House in Hiriketiya town of the Southern province. (AP)

LIBERIA

US sends 20 deportees

The United States sent 20 deportees to Liberia, who arrived on Thursday as part of 1,200 migrants that the African country will receive under a new deal. The deportees arrived at the Roberts International Airport outside Monrovia. The Liberia-US agreement is among the largest third-country deportations driven by the Trump administration's crackdown on immigration.

The 1,200 deportees will include African nationals and also nationals from North America, South America and the Caribbean, according to Liberian Information Minister Jerolinmek Piah.

During a briefing on Tuesday, Liberian Justice Minister Natu Oswald Tweh said that the majority of the deportees had committed migration-related violations and offenses, and that they could seek asylum in the West African country if they wished. (AP)

Iran slams US sanctions threat while UK condemns Israel

ASSOCIATED PRESS n Dubai

Iran on Thursday dismissed US President Donald Trump's threats of economic pain and isolation, while the UK and other nations condemned Israel over a controversial settlement project.

Meanwhile, Syria's foreign minister visited Pakistan, which is seeking to defuse tensions between the United States and Iran. Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi has rejected the economic threats made against his country, saying that such "failed policies" will stir more hostility among Iranians and "bring more failures."

Araghchi's comments came a few hours after President Donald Trump threatened "crushing economic measures" against Iran. Trump promised "Economic



Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi

Warfare and Isolation on an unprecedented scale," but provided few details.

In a social media post, Araghchi maintained the threats aim to divert the attention of the US public from domestic financial problems, adding that the US "economic terrorism threatens the global economy and the national sovereignty of countries around the world."

Several countries condemned the latest development in a contentious Israeli settlement project near Jerusalem that would effectively cut the occupied West Bank in two. Israel's Ministry of Construction and Housing issued a tender for constructing several compounds, with more than 1,200 homes in total in an open tract of land east of Jerusalem. It's the

latest step in a project under consideration for more than two decades, which critics say would prevent the establishment of a contiguous Palestinian state in the territory.

British Foreign Secretary Ed Miliband called the publication of the tender "an unacceptable and destructive act" and denounced "settler violence and terrorism." In a statement released on Wednesday, he added that the British Government "demanded an immediate reversal" and had summoned the Israeli Charge d'Affaires. Egypt and Jordan also condemned Israel's move, which Cairo said would isolate east Jerusalem from its Palestinian surroundings. Israeli Prime Minister Gideon Sa'ar responded on Thursday by defending "the historic right of the Jewish

people to reestablish their national home in the Land of Israel — including in the area in question." Sa'ar criticised Britain's Government for "blaming only Israel while ignoring Palestinian extremism."

Turkey has denied that a Turkish military delegation had visited an air base in northern Syria that was hit by Israeli airstrikes, and vowed to continue supporting Syria in its efforts to rebuild its military.

The Israeli strikes targeted the Abu Duhur base early on Tuesday, causing damage but no casualties. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's office said Israel had attacked the base because Syria was "on the verge of breaching" an agreed-upon "status quo in security matters" by allowing Turkish troops to deploy there.

BNP's Alamgir elected as Bangladesh's new President

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA n Dhaka

Mirza Fakhru Islam Alamgir, a longtime secretary general of the ruling Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) and a close ally of former premier Khaleda Zia, was on Thursday elected as the country's new President in the first contested poll for the post in 35 years.

The 78-year-old BNP stalwart defeated his lone rival Colonel (ret'd) Oli Ahmed, the 84-year-old Liberal Democratic Party chairman and the nominee of the Jamaat-e-Islami-led 11-party opposition alliance, Chief Election Commissioner and also Election Returning Officer AMM Nasir Uddin announced after the counting of votes. Of the total 349 registered voters, 343 voted in the election. Six lawmakers didn't vote, he said.

Alamgir secured 255 votes while Oli Ahmad bagged 88 votes. He will take the oath as Bangladesh's 23rd President on Friday evening at the Darbar Hall of Bangabhaban.

It is the first contested presidential election in Bangladesh since 1991, as the office had largely been filled through consensus and uncontested polls in recent decades. Prime Minister Tarique Rahman congratulated Alamgir on his victory in the presidential polls. Lawmakers also congratulated the President-elect by thumping their desks.

As opposition lawmakers, including Leader of the Opposition Dr Shafiqur Rahman and Deputy Leader Syed Abdullah Mohammad Taher, approached the trea-



sury bench, Alamgir came forward and embraced Rahman, the State-run BSS news agency reported.

The presidential election was necessitated after Mohammed Shahabuddin, a close aide of deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina, resigned last month on health grounds before completing his five-year tenure.

Under the Constitution, a new president is required to be elected within 90 days of the office falling vacant. Parliamentary Speaker Hafiz Uddin Ahmad is currently serving as acting president, as required under the Constitution following a vacancy in the office.

The president is elected by Members of Parliament under Bangladesh's constitutional system.

The BNP, which was voted to power in the February 12 elections, currently commands a two-thirds majority in Parliament.

Bangladesh PM unlikely to visit India for BRICS

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA n Dhaka

The possibility of Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman's visit to India next month for BRICS Summit "remains slim" unless an appropriate environment based on "mutual trust" is created, along with a "dignified invitation" from New Delhi, his Foreign Affairs Adviser Humaiun Kobir has said.

He said Dhaka is in no hurry to arrange a top-level visit without clearly defined national interests.

"There is no justification for rushing into a top-level visit by going beyond the national interest," Kobir told State-run BSS news agency in an interview published on Thursday. The interview was held on August 17. The comments came amid uncertainties over Rahman's visit to New Delhi for the BRICS summit on September 12-13 amid fresh strains in bilateral ties over Dhaka's demand for the extra-



Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman

dition of deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina.

"The possibility of the Prime Minister visiting India ahead of the upcoming BRICS Summit remains slim unless an appropriate environment is created based on consensus between the two countries on specific issues and a dignified invitation," Kobir said. However, he said,

Afghanistan's Taliban releases 2 UN staffers

ELENA BECATOROS n Kabul

Afghanistan's Taliban rulers have released two United Nations staff members whom they detained more than a week ago, the UN said on Thursday, adding that the reason for the two men's detention remains unclear.

The arrests were the latest in a series of detentions by Afghanistan's Taliban authorities. Last week, the advocacy group Human Rights Watch said six staff members of a local organisation working on women's and children's rights had been "forcibly disappeared" for more than a month.

The United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan said its two employees, who were



detained in the western city of Herat on August 9, were released Thursday morning and appeared to be in good health.

"UNAMA has not been formally notified of the reasons for their arrest and detention and continues to follow up with the de facto authorities," the UN said in a statement, adding that it

ities did not immediately comment on the UN staff members' release.

The UN mission's mandate from the UN Security Council includes promoting and supporting humanitarian assistance to the Afghan people, promoting human rights, equality for women and girls, inclusive governance and economic stability.

On August 12, Human Rights Watch said six senior members from the Women and Children Legal Research Foundation were detained on July 18 after they were told to come to their office to retrieve laptops and phones confiscated during a raid on the organisation's offices about a month earlier. (AP)

Six million Somali faces another hunger crisis

OMAR FARUK n Mogadishu

Six million people in Somalia are facing acute food insecurity while the World Food Programme has only a tenth of the resources it had in 2022 when it helped avert famine in the drought- and conflict-stricken East African nation, the head of the UN agency said.

"We can only do the bare minimum," WFP executive director Carl Skau said Wednesday during a visit to a nutrition centre on the outskirts of the Capital, Mogadishu. "We're only providing these nutrition supplies to the children that are really the worst hit."

The reduced funds, because of cuts in international aid by donors and



the redirection of resources to other humanitarian crises, meant that the WFP is unable to expand its assistance in Somalia, Skau said. Millions of people at risk but far less aid The WFP projects that 1.9 million children under age 5 in the country will suffer acute malnutrition this year, including nearly 500,000 who

will require urgent treatment for severe acute malnutrition. Overall, around 30 per cent of the population faces critical levels of food insecurity, the UN has said.

"We had 10 times more resources than now," Skau said of the 2022 hunger emergency that was caused by a prolonged drought. "We

were able to step in, and we prevented a famine in Somalia." "We know what's going on, we have the capacity, we have the experience of dealing with this. We just need the resources now to do it."

The consequences of the current food shortage, which is also a result of drought, conflict and the displacement of people, are seen at the Feynuus Health Centre in Mogadishu's Kahda district. Dozens of women carrying babies waited beneath a large tree or crowded along the veranda of the corrugated-metal facility seeking help. Health workers placed children in a blue weighing sling, screened them for malnutrition, and distributed therapeutic food. (AP)

Belgian mountaineers found in Swiss Alps after three decades

ASSOCIATED PRESS n Geneva

The bodies of two Belgian mountaineers who went missing in the Swiss Alps more than three decades ago have been found, officials said.

Police in the southwestern Valais region, which has a database of people listed as missing over the last century, said the retreat of glaciers has led to the emergence of remains of people who went missing decades earlier.

Late last month, a hiker discovered human remains that turned up following the melting of the Trift glacier south of the city of Lucerne, prompting a recovery operation, the regional Government said Wednesday.

DNA tests conducted at a Valais hospital determined that the remains were those of two Belgian hikers, aged 39 and 41 at the time, who went missing near the Weissmies mountain — dozens of kilometers to the



south — in 1992. Such discoveries are nothing new but have become more frequent as Switzerland's glaciers have melted at an increasing rate. Three years ago, DNA tests confirmed that a body found on a Swiss glacier near the Matterhorn was that of a German mountaineer who disappeared in 1986.

Many scientists blame global warming for a recent surge in glacier melt in Switzerland and beyond.

Taiwan proposes record \$35 billion defence budget to deter Chinese threats

ASSOCIATED PRESS n Taipei

Taiwan Government on Thursday proposed a record-high defence budget of 1.12 trillion Taiwan dollars (\$35 billion) for next year, signalling intensifying efforts to deter China's military threats.

The administration's planned increase in military spending came after China stepped up its military and political pressure in recent years, asserting its claims that Taiwan was part of its sovereignty.

China sends military planes, as well as coast guard ships and other vessels, toward Taiwan regularly and carries out large-scale military exercises from time to time. It has not renounced the use of force to bring the island under its control. Under Taiwan's plans,



the island's defence spending next year will exceed 3 per cent of its estimated gross domestic product. The amount would be an

18 per cent jump from last year's proposed budget, according to a Government statement.

The Government's overall

spending plans, including on defence, will be sent to the opposition-controlled legislature for review before late August, it said. But the process may come with some challenges.

The legislature only passed the central Government's 2026 budget last Friday, after a record 266-day delay, Taiwan's Central News Agency reported.

Taiwan's President Lai Ching-te previously pledged to raise defence spending to 5 per cent of the island's GDP by 2030. On Monday, Lai said next year's defence budget would go beyond 1 trillion Taiwan dollars for the first time, adding that investing in national defence is an investment in peace. Earlier this month, the island ramped up the intensity of

its annual Han Kuang drills, aimed at modelling a response to a possible Chinese military invasion.

It incorporated reservists and more civilians into the exercises with a focus on real-world scenarios. Mobile internet in parts of Taiwan was briefly slowed to text-only speed. Previously, urban resilience drills in Taipei went largely unnoticed as they were not disruptive.

The United States has demanded that Taiwan raise its defence spending. Washington does not have formal diplomatic relations with Taiwan, but maintains extensive unofficial relations and is required under US law to provide Taiwan with the means to defend itself. Under that framework, the US has long been Taiwan's main

informal backer and arms supplier, a relationship that created tensions with Beijing.

When US President Donald Trump visited Beijing in May, China's President Xi Jinping warned him that their two countries could clash over Taiwan if the issue is not handled properly.

After Trump's trip to Beijing, he said arms sales to Taiwan were a "very good negotiating chip" with China, comments that stirred anxieties on the island.

China and Taiwan have been governed separately since 1949, when a civil war brought the Communist Party to power in Beijing. Defeated Nationalist Party forces fled to Taiwan. The island has operated since then with its own Government.

Train hits, kills 4 workers at railway station in Japan



MARI YAMAGUCHI n Tokyo

Four people doing weed control work on a railway track in Japan died after being hit by an express train as it entered a station while they were still working there on Thursday, officials said.

The accident occurred at Shin-Kanuma Station, north of Tokyo, on the Tobu Nikko Line, and involved the Tokyo-bound Spacia express train, the Tochigi prefectural police said. The four — three workers and a supervisor — were rushed to a hospital but later pronounced dead, according to police and train operator Tobu Railway Co.

Six other people at the site — two other workers, three on lookout duty and an on-site supervisor — were safe, Tobu Railway said. They had been assigned to spray herbicide. About 50 passengers on the train were also uninjured.

Railway officials said it was unclear why the workers did not leave the site when the train was approaching, or what the lookout people were doing. They said they are cooperating with authorities investigating the cause of the accident.

Those on lookout duty are supposed to warn fellow workers of an approaching train by waving a flag, using a whistle or a microphone. What happened Thursday before and during the accident was still under investigation, Tobu officials said.

Fatal train accidents are rare in Japan, which has a reputation for safe and punctual transportation.

Takao Suzuki, head of Tobu's railway business division, apologised for the fatal accident. "We take this severe accident seriously and we will ensure preventive measures and never let this happen," he said. (AP)

Singapore PM holds bilateral talks with Indian ministers

GURDIP SINGH n Singapore

Prime Minister Lawrence Wong on Thursday met visiting Indian ministers ahead of the fourth India-Singapore Ministerial Roundtable (ISMR) and discussed ways to build on the progress made in bilateral ties, particularly in advanced manufacturing, digitalisation, sustainability and connectivity.

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal, and Minister of State for Electronics and IT Jitin Prasada are in the city-state to participate in the ministerial-level meeting. In a series of social media posts, Wong said it was a pleasure to



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal and Minister of State Jitin Prasada, pose for a group photograph alongside Singaporean Deputy Prime Minister Gan Kim Yong and other senior dignitaries during the India-Singapore Ministerial Roundtable (ISMR), in Singapore.

PTI

catch up with Sitharaman, Jaishankar, Goyal and Prasada ahead of the ISMR, which began on Thursday.

The leaders discussed how Singapore and India can “build on the good progress made through ISMR” and take the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership further, especially in advanced manufacturing, digitalisation, sustainability and connectivity. Wong said the discussions also covered regional and global developments.

“Singapore and India share a longstanding and increasingly close partnership. I wish the ministers a productive visit and fruitful discussions at the ISMR,” he said. According to a Singapore Government statement, the ISMR is an

important ministerial-level platform for the two countries to drive cooperation in new and emerging areas.

The fourth ISMR will review the progress from the third ISMR, held in New Delhi in August 2025, and identify new opportunities to advance the implementation of the Singapore India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership Roadmap, the ministries of Foreign Affairs and Trade and Industry said in a joint statement.

Sitharaman is leading the Indian delegation, while Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Trade and Industry (Trade) Gan Kim Yong is heading the Singapore delegation at the fourth roundtable. (PTI)

Telangana CM in London at start of 10-day UK, US tour



ADITI KHANNA n London

Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy has kicked off a 10-day tour of the UK and US after arriving in London on Thursday. In the UK, Reddy is scheduled to visit the Blavatnik School of Government at the University of Oxford and the Emirates Stadium for an EPL Football presentation, according to the State Government.

Interactions and events are also planned with the University of Cambridge, University of London and London Business School (LBS) during the first leg of his two-nation tour.

The Telagana CM will then head to the US next week, where he is set to visit the

campuses of Harvard University and Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT).

He is also scheduled to interact with a team from Virginia Tech University in Boston on August 25.

Besides some official discussions, a meet-and-greet diaspora event organised by the US chapter of the Indian Overseas Congress (IOC) in New York is also on the agenda. Earlier, Congress MP Mallu Ravi and the state Government’s advisor on protocol affairs, Harkara Venugopal, saw him off at the New Delhi airport in the early hours of Thursday.

Reddy was in New Delhi to attend the Congress Working Committee (CWC) meeting on Wednesday. (PTI)

Russian missile, drone strikes kill 16 in Ukraine

ASSOCIATED PRESS n Kyiv

Russia pounded the Ukrainian Capital Kyiv and the surrounding region with scores of missiles and drones in a nighttime aerial attack that lasted for hours and killed at least 16 people, officials said on Thursday.

Moscow’s forces have in recent months intensified their ballistic missile attacks on Kyiv, exploiting Ukraine’s chronic shortage of US-made Patriot air defence interceptors, the sole weapon in its arsenal able to shoot down ballistic missiles.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy has pleaded for countries to send more Patriot interceptors, but international stockpiles are low amid the Iran war and Ukraine’s more than

four-year fight against Russia’s all-out invasion.

Russia’s overnight barrage also included cruise missiles and fast-flying jet-powered drones that put further strain on air defences, the Ukrainian air force said.

Explosions boomed across the city in the dark. Kyiv was the primary target, but hits were recorded at 28 locations across the country, according to the air force.

Emergency services said 15 people were killed in the capital, with another fatality in the wider Kyiv region. About 40 people were wounded, Zelenskyy said, as air raid warnings remained in place until after dawn.

“It was a massive attack,” Zelenskyy said on social media, adding that Russia “had been preparing (it) for



People taking shelter in a metro station in Kyiv, Ukraine

AP

a long time, combining different types of ballistic missiles, cruise missiles and drones, aiming to cause as much damage as possible to civilian infrastructure.”

But the Russian Defence

Ministry said the attack struck a Kyiv industrial site manufacturing components for Ukraine’s Flamingo cruise missiles.

Sites involved in the production and storage of

drones, an ammunition depot and a logistics centre were also hit, it said.

Russia and Ukraine have battered each other with drones and missiles as their armies struggle to gain the upper hand on the 1250-kilometre front line, where huge numbers of drones are pinning down troops.

Ukraine has attempted to shift the war onto Russian soil through long-range drone strikes on oil facilities and other infrastructure.

The Russian Defence Ministry said Thursday morning that air defences shot down 726 Ukrainian drones overnight over a number of Russian regions, annexed Crimea and the Black and Azov seas, in one of Ukraine’s biggest aerial attacks of the war.

North Korea fires suspected missile toward sea, Japan claims



ASSOCIATED PRESS n Seoul

North Korea launched a suspected ballistic missile toward the sea on Thursday, Japan said, a day after North Korea shrugged off a US decision to scale back military drills with South Korea in an apparent bid to resume diplomacy. The Japanese prime minister’s office said it detected the suspected launch but gave no further details.

South Korean media, citing the military, reported that North Korea fired an unidentified projectile off the North’s east coast.

On Wednesday, the South Korean and US militaries said they were scaling back their 11-day Ulchi Freedom Shield exercises. US President Donald Trump earlier ordered the Pentagon to “substantially reduce” the exercises, just before they began on Monday. Trump cited what he said was a good relationship with Kim and South Korea’s refusal to support him over the war in Iran.

Collision with helicopter kills US pilot: Authorities



ASSOCIATED PRESS n Washington

An airplane pilot died on Wednesday after a violent collision with a Pennsylvania State Police helicopter near a runway at a small airport, but both state troopers aboard the helicopter survived, authorities said.

The plane was coming down on the runway and veered into the helicopter that was near the ground, Lieutenant Colonel George Bivens, the State’s acting police commissioner, said during a news conference.

The FAA and NTSB called it a midair collision but state police didn’t clarify if the plane was off the ground. “When I say it was a very violent crash, that plane was cut into a lot of pieces,” he said, explaining that part of the investigation will be making sure the pilot was the only person on board. He said the helicopter lost its blades and tail boom and crashed onto its side. The crash at the

small airport in Carlisle, about 170 kilometers northwest of Philadelphia, involved the Bell 407 helicopter and the Cessna 150, according to the Federal Aviation Administration. The Cessna is a two-seat aircraft that is typically used as a trainer aircraft, according to Bivens.

Both of the pilots in the helicopter were trapped until one pushed out a window and helped the other out through it, said Bivens. The pilots, who are from the police’s elite aviation unit and had been performing a training exercise, are stable.

“Tonight could’ve been much worse,” said Governor Josh Shapiro. “Tonight could have been much more tragic for our state police family.” Officials are not releasing information about the person who died in the crash until the person’s next of kin are informed. Photos and video on social media showed a helicopter on its side near aircraft debris in a field and a line of emergency vehicles near Carlisle.

WHO to send 70,000 vaccine doses to Congo to curb Ebola

ASSOCIATED PRESS n Bunia

Congo will receive 70,000 doses of the Ervebo vaccine, which has been effective in past Ebola outbreaks, the World Health Organisation and partners said on Thursday, announcing a step seen as a major boost to efforts to contain what officials have described as the fastest Ebola outbreak in history.

The Ervebo vaccine is licensed for use against Ebola virus, one of the viruses that cause Ebola disease, but not for Bundibugyo virus, which is responsible for the current outbreak.

WHO said in a statement that while it’s not known whether Ervebo may protect against the Bundibugyo virus, “early laboratory and animal data suggest it may



provide some protection.”

The allocation includes 20,000 doses for a Phase 3 clinical trial to understand the impact of the vaccine on the Bundibugyo virus, the agency said. The remaining 50,000 doses will be used for front-line and health workers as recommended by WHO experts.

6 injured sailors, bodies of 2 killed return to Pakistan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA n Karachi

Six Pakistani seafarers injured in a recent Houthi attack on a commercial vessel in the Red Sea safely returned home on Thursday, while the mortal remains of the two sailors who were killed in the assault have also been repatriated.

On August 11, four seafarers — three Pakistanis and an Indonesian — were killed and several others injured after Tanzania-flagged vessel ‘Tihamah’ was targeted in the Bab el-Mandeb Strait by the Iranian-backed Houthis, who have intensified attacks following the announcement of a maritime ban on Saudi-linked vessels last month.



“The six Pakistani sailors injured in the recent Houthi attack on a Tanzanian-flagged commercial vessel have safely returned to Pakistan, while the mortal

remains of the two Pakistani sailors who tragically lost their lives have also been repatriated,” Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar said in a

post on X on Thursday.

Saudi Airlines flight SV700 brought the deceased Pakistani sailors and two injured crew members, while Pakistan International Airlines flight PK-762 brought the remaining four injured to Karachi, according to officials.

Officials from the Saudi Embassy and the Pakistan Government received them at the Karachi airport.

Dar said all relevant stakeholders have been directed to ensure their safe, dignified and expeditious repatriation. He commended the Consulate General of Pakistan in Jeddah and its Embassy in Riyadh for their prompt and dedicated efforts in facilitating the return of the injured and repatriation of the bodies

from Yemen and onward travel to Pakistan.

He also appreciated the cooperation extended by the Saudi Foreign Ministry, including the medical assistance and arrangements provided in Jeddah.

“Pakistan condemns the attack in the strongest terms and reiterates that the safety and security of seafarers must be ensured at all times. We remain committed to extending all possible assistance to the injured sailors and the bereaved families,” he added.

The Pakistan Government had been facing relentless pressure to secure the release of the sailors, with their families holding media conferences regularly to highlight their plight. (PTI)

scale mining, often with little protection. Pits are frequently dug by hand and can reach several metres deep.

Without adequate reinforcement, shifting ground can cause tunnels to collapse suddenly, burying miners within seconds.

Researchers and local media reported earlier this year on unsafe and unregulated mining associated with a rapidly expanding gold rush around Zamboye, where the mine collapsed.

A 2025 report by UN experts documented illicit mining in the area, including the involvement of armed groups and the use of extraction methods that posed health and environmental risks. (AP)

Founder of Chinese troubled property giant Evergrande gets life term



KJM VARMA n Beijing

A Chinese court on Thursday sentenced Xu Jiayan, former boss of Evergrande Group, the property giant at the centre of China’s housing market slump, to life in prison for multiple crimes and ordered confiscation of all his personal property.

The Shenzhen Intermediate People’s Court has fined Xu Jiayan CNY 8.82 billion and the Evergrande Group’s onshore operating unit Hengda Real Estate CNY 7 billion.

These are some of the biggest corporate fines levied by a Chinese court for criminal charges, State-run Xinhua news agency reported.

Xu, also known as Hui Ka Yan, was deprived of political rights for life. The court found Xu guilty of illegally absorbing public deposits, fundraising fraud, fraudulent issuance of securities, unlawful disclosure of important information, and corporate bribery, State-run Xinhua news agency reported. (PTI)

Rescuers recover more bodies after Central African Republic mine collapse kills over 100

JEAN FERNAND KOENA n Bangui

Hopes of finding survivors of a collapsed gold mine in Central African Republic were fading Thursday, two days after the disaster killed more than 100 people and left others buried under debris.

Rescuers continued recovering bodies from the artisanal mining site in Zamboye, near the border with Cameroon, but local workers said the response lacked the equipment and expertise needed for a disaster of such scale.

“The rescue effort is being organised, but it is not up to the task,” said Jeremie Ngbiri, a miner at the site who lost



his brother and a friend in the collapse. Ngbiri said he saw some victims suffocate as people tried to rescue them.

The local Red Cross was helping with the search but could not say how many people remained buried, volunteer Gervais Ganagoro said.

“We continue to find bodies,” he said, adding that more than 10 were recovered Thursday morning alone. “Every hour, bodies are being discovered, increasing the number of victims.”

The mine collapsed Tuesday after a landslide. Local officials and the Red Cross said Wednesday that more than 100 people had died and warned the toll was likely to rise. Mines Minister

Rufin Benam Beltoungou expressed condolences to victims’ families and warned miners about the dangers of unsafe mining practices, according to a statement posted by the ministry.

Some of the victims were from neighbouring Cameroon. Cameroon’s Mines Ministry said both Cameroonian and Central African miners were believed to be among the dead and deployed a team to assess the situation along the border. The state-run Cameroon Tribune reported at least four Cameroonians were killed.

Artisanal mine collapses are common in Central African Republic, where thousands of people work in small-

(PNS)

(PNS)



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- 12, Venom
- 13, B-alone-y

The EOW investigation, if undertaken, will determine whether the alleged transactions occurred as claimed and whether any legal or regulatory violations took place.

BRIEFLY

Asian junior chess: Win for Chakraborty, Vignesh loses



Top seed Mayank Chakraborty began his campaign with an impressive win while two leading contenders – Vignesh Advait Vemula and Akhilbay Imangali – were held to a draw by lower-rated opponents in the Asian Junior Classical Championship here on Thursday. Vignesh was forced to share the point with Neemay Bhanushali, while Imangali of Kazakhstan was held by Rishaan Jain. The opening round in the girls section, however, produced a couple of notable upsets. Swara Lakshmi S Nair was held to a draw by Vakcheri Mohitha despite enjoying a significant rating advantage, while Aadya Gowda scored an impressive victory over the higher-rated WFM Mittika Mallick.

Another surprise result saw Liliya Belaya of Uzbekistan defeat the higher-rated Archita Agrawal of India. The Open Championship has attracted a strong field of 85 players representing nine federations. The tournament features six International Masters and eleven FIDE Masters, making it one of the strongest junior events in Asia. Leading the field is top seed International Master Mayank Chakraborty of India, rated 2500. The girls championship has attracted players from seven federations. The top three seeds, WFM Pratitee Bordoloi of India, WFM Mariya Kholyavko of Kazakhstan and WFM Shohradova Lala of Turkmenistan, opened their campaigns with convincing victories to move into the lead group after the first round. The championship was inaugurated by Grandmaster Vidit Gujrathi, who has been named a recipient of the prestigious Arjuna Award.

(PTI)

PSG moves its opening French league game at Parc des Princes



Paris Saint-Germain's opening game of its title defense in the French league against Rennes has been relocated at short notice because of damage to the champion's pitch following a heatwave this summer. Sunday's match will now take place in Rennes, French soccer's competitions committee announced late Wednesday. PSG said its pitch at Parc des Princes had deteriorated so much "that the current conditions did not allow the match to be held under satisfactory circumstances, particularly with regard to the safety and physical well-being of the players." The change of venue has been decided "in agreement" with Rennes, PSG said, and thanked its opponent for "making the match possible." "Paris Saint-Germain fully understands the inconvenience caused by this change for its supporters and all those who had planned to attend this match at the Parc des Princes," PSG added, saying "the club regrets this exceptional situation." PSG said it had "identified a solution for replacing the pitch at the Parc des Princes for the upcoming matches," starting with its next home game in Ligue 1 against Monaco on Sept. 4.

(AP)

Neeraj-Pathirage showdown yet again in Lausanne

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
n Lausanne

The budding rivalry between rising Sri Lankan star Rumesh Pathirage and Indian ace Neeraj Chopra will once again be an intriguing battle when the two square off in the Lausanne Diamond League meet here on Friday with a spot in the DL grand finale in Brussels at stake.

The duo will be up against each other three weeks after Pathirage clinched the gold and Chopra finished with a silver in the Glasgow Commonwealth Games.

The 23-year-old Pathirage has been in the form of his life this season, having also won the Doha and Rome Diamond

League meetings, besides clinching gold in Glasgow with a throw of 89.75m. He also breached the coveted 90m mark with a season-leading throw of 92.62m in Rome in June.

In fact, the Sri Lankan has won eight of the nine competitions he has participated so far in the season.

Chopra, on the other hand, is on a comeback trail after recovering from a lower back injury that has troubled him since September last year.

The injury delayed his return until the Diamond League in Doha. He was not 100 per cent fit in Glasgow but was able to win a silver with a season's best throw of 85.83m. "I can't say my fitness



is there like before. But I'm getting there slowly," the 28-year-old Chopra had said at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games. After the Commonwealth Games,

Chopra has gone back to his base in Biel, Switzerland, where he is continuing his rehabilitation-cum-training with childhood coach Jaiver Chaudhary and physio Ishan

German Cup faces disruption with fans planning protests

CIARAN FAHEY n Berlin

The first round of the German Cup faces disruption this weekend with several supporter groups planning major protests against the use of video technology during games.

The new German soccer season begins Friday with Bundesliga teams Eintracht Frankfurt and Stuttgart facing lower-league opposition among other games, with the first round continuing through the weekend and Monday.

There will be no video assistance for referees in the first round for technical and financial reasons with 64 teams involved, but VAR will be introduced from the



second round for the first time this season. News agency DPA on Thursday published a statement it said was circulating among the fanbases of teams involved, declaring their intent to protest. "We see football as it should be in the first round of the cup getting under-

way now — without VAR and thus authentic, immediate, and full of emotion. We want to return to this state permanently and therefore call for the abolition of the video assistant referee (VAR) in German football," the statement said. "While football thrives on intensity and

rhythm, the flow of the game suffers significantly from protracted interruptions. We are also painfully aware that it has destroyed the game's most emotional moments," it continued. "Even fans who were initially open to and positive about the innovation now acknowledge, after nine years, that VAR has fundamentally altered the character of the game."

Fans have interrupted games before in Germany using tennis balls or pyrotechnics. Last season's German Cup final was played under a cloud of smoke from fans' fireworks. This season in Germany, the referee's video assistant's powers are to be expanded. (AP)

Golf: Theegala needs top finish for Tour Championship

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
n St Louis (US)

Sahith Theegala needs a finish pretty close to the top to make it to the Tour Championship as he tees up for the 2026 BMW Championship which is a high-stakes week on the PGA Tour. The event cuts down the field to the top 50 players. The 2026 BMW Championship runs from August 20-23 at East Lake.

Hosted at the historic Bellerive Country Club in St. Louis, Missouri, this Par 70, 7,448-yard track features over 70 penal sand traps, demanding elite ball-striking and precision long-iron play.

With a massive \$20 million purse on the line, there is no 36-hole cut, guaranteeing four full days of intense

drama as the field claws for the ultimate prize.

The field of 50 will be trimmed to 30 after this week's BMW Championship and it carries another set of rewards. For starters, those 30 will play at the TOUR Championship for the chance to be crowned the FedExCup champion. The other carrot is exemptions into next year's majors.

One of the historic storylines of the 2026 FedEx Cup Playoffs is the unprecedented representation of Indian-origin golfers. A record-breaking group of four players advanced through to the Play-offs and three have secured their places in this week's elite 50-man field.

They are Hero-supported Akshay Bhatia and Sahith Theegala and Aaron Rai, who



have all ensured they will play the Signature events next season. Rai alone, as the PGA Championship winner, will be into all the Majors next year. The others will need to be inside the Top-30 for that. Theegala plays his first round with Justin Thomas, while Rai is paired with Ben Griffin and Bhatia goes out with Hideki Matsuyama. Bhatia is best placed at No. 15 in the FedEx Cup standings, the three-time PGA Tour winner

is the highest-ranked Indian-origin player in the field. Bhatia captured a Signature Event victory earlier this season at the Arnold Palmer Invitational and has essentially locked up his spot for East Lake. Aaron Rai, the steady English-Indian golfer sits at No. 37 in the standings. Having captured a breakthrough Major title at the PGA Championship earlier this year, Rai needs a strong showing at Bellerive to jump into the top 30. Sahith Theegala, a big fan favourite on the tour, is No. 46 in the standings. While his spot in next year's \$20 million Signature Events is secure by making the top 50, he faces an uphill battle and needs something like Top-3 or better to advance to the playoff finale.

'Synthetic shuttlecocks trialed at 4 events since June, no deadline for implementation'

AMIT KUMAR DAS
n New Delhi

The Badminton World Federation has already run its synthetic feather shuttlecock trials at four international tournaments over the past two months, with governing body Secretary General Thomas Lund on Thursday saying synthetic products are now "getting quite close" to the standards required for elite-level play, though there is no fixed deadline for their implementation.

The trials were held at the TOYOTA Phuket International Challenge 2026 (June 9-14), the Valence Alpes International 2026 presented by FZ FORZA (June 11-14), the FZ FORZA Future Series Nouvelle-Aquitaine 2026 (July 2-5), and the VICTOR Irish U19 Open 2026 (August 7-9), according to BWF.

The spread of events — an International Challenge, a Future Series leg and a Junior International Series tournament — indicates BWF has been testing the synthetic shuttlecocks across different tiers of competition below the elite level.

Asked about the availability of shuttlecocks and the ongoing experimentation with synthetic alternatives, Lund said the issue was "a little bit more complex" than a straightforward supply crisis. "That's a big question and it's a little bit more complex than maybe, you know, is there a problem? There's plenty of shuttlecocks and super good shuttlecocks being played with at this tournament, at the top level. But over the last maybe 30, 40

years... there's been a bird flu thing, and that has created a little bit of wobbly times with the supply chains. Price increases going a little bit up and down," Lund told reporters on the sidelines of the World Championships.

BWF had announced in April that it would trial two synthetic feather shuttlecocks — the VICTOR New Carbon Sonic Max and the YONEX CROSSWIND 70 — after internal testing showed the products had reached performance levels that justified evaluation in real competition. Lund acknowledged that



developing a synthetic shuttlecock capable of matching the performance of a natural-feather product has proved

challenging. "That is hard work because you develop something and then you find out that it

improved this but then two steps back and something else. That's going back and forth," he said. "The short answer is we are very supportive of helping the manufacturers get to a place where we have both natural feather but then also a synthetic feather option in the market," Lund said. "Obviously, to play with it at a World Championship it needs to actually live up to quite high standards," he said. "And some of them are getting quite close with that, so it's super impressive." BWF also hopes wider adoption of syn-

thetic feather shuttlecocks could eventually help moderate prices, Lund said.

Aadhar Housing Finance Ltd.

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Authorised Officer : Lokendra Rathore, Mobile No. 9977783890

NOTICE FOR SALE OF PROPERTY UNDER PROVISIONS OF SARFAESI ACT, 2002 THROUGH PRIVATE TREATY

Whereas the Authorised Officer of Aadhar Housing Finance Limited (AHFL) has taken the Possession of the Secured Asset, u/s 13(4) of the Securitisation & Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002. And whereas the Authorized Officer had earlier issued E auction Notices but failed to attract any successful bidders, and has now decided to sell the Secured Asset given below by way of Private Treaty. The Authorised Officer has received an offer from some interested persons in this regard for purchase of the Secured Asset. The Authorised Officer is hereby giving the Notice to the Borrowers in general, for Sale of the above said property through Private Treaty in terms of rule 8 and 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002. The Details of the Account are as follows:

Sr No.	Loan Code No./ Branch	Name of the Borrower/ Co-Borrowers	Demand Notice Date & Amount	Reserve Price (RP)	Total Outstanding Loan Amount as on 27.07.2026	Description of the Secured Asset
1.	(Loan Code No. 02300001452 & 02300001695 / Sagar Branch)	Arun Sen (Borrower) Shakun Sen (Co-Borrower)	24-08-2022 ₹ 8,08,637/-	₹ 5,00,000/-	₹ 15,69,144/- ₹ 2,48,667/-	All that piece and parcel of the property bearing, Kh No. 105 I 25, P.H.No. 47, Ward No. 23, Indra Gandhi Ward, Mouja Sabda, Sagar, M.P. 470113 Boundaries: East: Way of Exit, West: Land of Seller, North: Way of Exit, South: Vacant Land of Seller

This is a **15 DAYS SALE NOTICE UNDER SARFAESI ACT, 2002** which is hereby given to the Borrower (s), Co-Borrower (s) and Guarantor (s) that the above described immovable property mortgaged/charged to the Secured Creditor, the **Physical Possession** of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer, will be sold by way of Private Treaty on "As is where is", "As is what is", and "Whatever there is" basis to recover the amount due to Aadhar Housing Finance Ltd., If the Borrower(s), co-borrower(s) have any buyer who is ready to purchase the secured asset at price above the given reserve price then Borrower(s), Co-borrower(s) must intimate to AHFL one day in advance before **10.09.2026** then AHFL shall give preference to him. If Borrower(s), co-borrower(s) fails to intimate one day in advance before **10.09.2026** the AHFL will proceed with sale of property at above given reserve price. The property is being sold with all the existing and future encumbrances whether known or unknown to AHFL. The Authorised Officer/ Secured Creditor shall not be responsible in any way for any third-party claims/rights/dues. The purchaser should conduct due diligence on all aspects related to the property (under sale through private treaty) to his satisfaction. The purchaser shall not be entitled to make any claim against the Authorised Officer/ Secured Creditor in this regard at a later date. **The Date of Sale is fixed for 10.09.2026**

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Place : Madhya Pradesh
Date : 21.08.2026

(Authorised Officer)
For Aadhar Housing Finance Limited

**Aadhar**
Housing Finance Ltd.

Corporate Office: Office Nos. 501 & 503,5th Floor,Lightbridge, Saki Vihar Road, Andheri East, Mumbai Suburban (District), MH– 400072
Sagar Branch : 1St Floor, Sakhi Baba Matrix,Makronia Road Sagar-470004,(MP).

Authorised Officer : Lokendra Rathore, Mobile No. 9977783890

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Place : Madhya Pradesh
Date : 21.08.2026

(Authorised Officer)
For Aadhar Housing Finance Limited

**केनरा बैंक Canara Bank**
Specialised ARM Branch, Jabalpur
Phone No.6232018014

E-AUCTION (SALE NOTICE)

Appendix-IV-A [See proviso to rule 8(6) & 9]

SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF MOVABLE & IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES

E-auction Sale Notice For Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with provision to Rules 8(6) & 9) of The Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002. Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) & Guarantor (s) that the below described immovable properties mortgaged / charged to the secured creditor, the **Symbolic & Physical possession** of which has been taken by the authorised officer the **Canara Bank (secured creditor)** will be sold on "AS IS WHERE IS BASIS, AS IS WHAT IS BASIS" & WHAT EVER THERE IS" on **15.09.2026** for recovery of bank dues to the **Canara Bank (secured creditor)**

Name and address of the Borrower & Guarantors	Description of Property	Demand Notice Dt. Possession Dt. Outstanding Amt.	Reserve Price EMD Amt. Bid Increment Amt.
1. MR. MANJEET PRATAP SINGH (Borrower & Mortgagor) Address 1: C/o Chhatra Pratap Singh H.No 81 Gram Bhandra Sihora Jabalpur (M.P.) 483334 Address 2: C/o Chhatra Pratap Singh, Sonpur Road, Mouza Ghana, Maharajpur, Gurananak Nagar, Tehsil & Dist- Jabalpur- 482005	Immovable Residential Property at Mouza Ghana P.H. No- 43 R.N.M- Maharajpur, Gurananak Nagar, Tehsil Panagar Dist- Jabalpur Land Bearing Old Khasra No 253/5 & 253/6 after diversion New P/o Khasra No 253/6/2 Sanctioned colonial layout Plot No 07 admeasuring 20*50 = 1000 Sq.ft and said plot prop P/o khasra no. 253/6/2 CERSAI Asset ID- 200071060323 Owner : Mr Manjeet Pratap Singh S/o Chhatra Pratap Singh Bounded: On the North by: Neighbours Property, On the South by: Plot No 8, On the East by: Prop of Nicolas Pal, On the West by: Colony Side Road BAANKNET PROPERTY ID: CNRBMJAJETP COORDINATES: 23.81536, 80.05545 Symbolic Possession	17.09.2025 28.11.2025 as on 19.08.2026 Rs. 34,80,953.38 + intt. & other charges	Rs. 16,00,000/- Rs. 1,60,000/- Rs.10,000/-
M/S SAI RAM AGENCIES Prioritor: KAPIL LALWANI Behind Govt School, Madhav Nagar, Katni (M.P.) 483501 Mr KAPIL LALWANI (Proprietor) Mrs SANDHYA LALWANI (Guarantor & Mortgager)	EMT of Land & Building situated at House No. 741, Survey No. B- 29, Patwari Halka No. 45/1 at Diverted Khasra No. 212/1, 212/4 (Part), Near Madhav Nagar Gate, Tehsil Bargawan, Shanti Nagar, Katni (MP), admeasuring 2185.50 sq.ft. CERSAI Asset ID- 100001037435 Owner : Smt Sandhya Lalwani W/o Sri Jagdish Lalwani Bounded: On the North by: House of Dr Suresh Lalwani, On the South by : House of Dr Vijay Lalwani, On the East by : 10 ft Wide kuliya & plot of Dr Nigam, On the West by: House of Mahendra Lalwani BAANKNET PROPERTY ID: CNRBSAGENCIES COORDINATES: 23.81536, 80.379940 Physical Possession	07.12.2016 13.02.2017 as on 19.08.2026 Rs. 3,31,58,433.68 + intt. & other charges	Rs. 37,90,000/- Rs. 3,79,000/- Rs.10,000/-

Last date for submission of online bids is on or before 14/09/2026 upto 5.00 p.m.
Date and Time of e-auction : 15/09/2026, 12:00 PM to 2:00 PM (With unlimited extension of 5 minutes duration each)

1) The Intending bidders shall deposit above mentioned Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) being 10% of the Reserve Price in E-Wallet of M/s PSB Alliance Private Limited (**baanknet.com**) portal directly or by generating the Challan therein to deposit the EMD through RTGS/NEFT in the account details as mentioned in the said challan. on above mentioned date of bid submission.

2) The successful bidder shall deposit 25% of the sale price (inclusive of EMD already paid), immediately on the sale being knocked down in his/her favour and the balance within 15 days from the date of confirmation of sale. If the successful bidder fails to pay the sale price as stated above, the deposit made by him shall be forfeited.

3) All charges for conveyance, stamp duty/GST registration charges etc, as applicable and any taxes, revenue/dues to any local authority etc shall be borne by the successful bidder only For further details Canara Bank, Specialised ARM Branch Jabalpur (Phone No.6232018014, 9755147130), e-mail id **cnb9014@canarabank.com** may be contacted during office hours on any working day or the service provider Baanknet (M/s PSB Alliance Pvt. Ltd), (Contact No. 7046612345/6354910172/8291220220/9892219848/8160205051, Email: support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com / support.abkray@procure247.com)

Date: 21.08.2026, Place: Jabalpur
AUTHORISED OFFICER, CANARA BANK

